HOOVER INSTITUTION | Stanford University

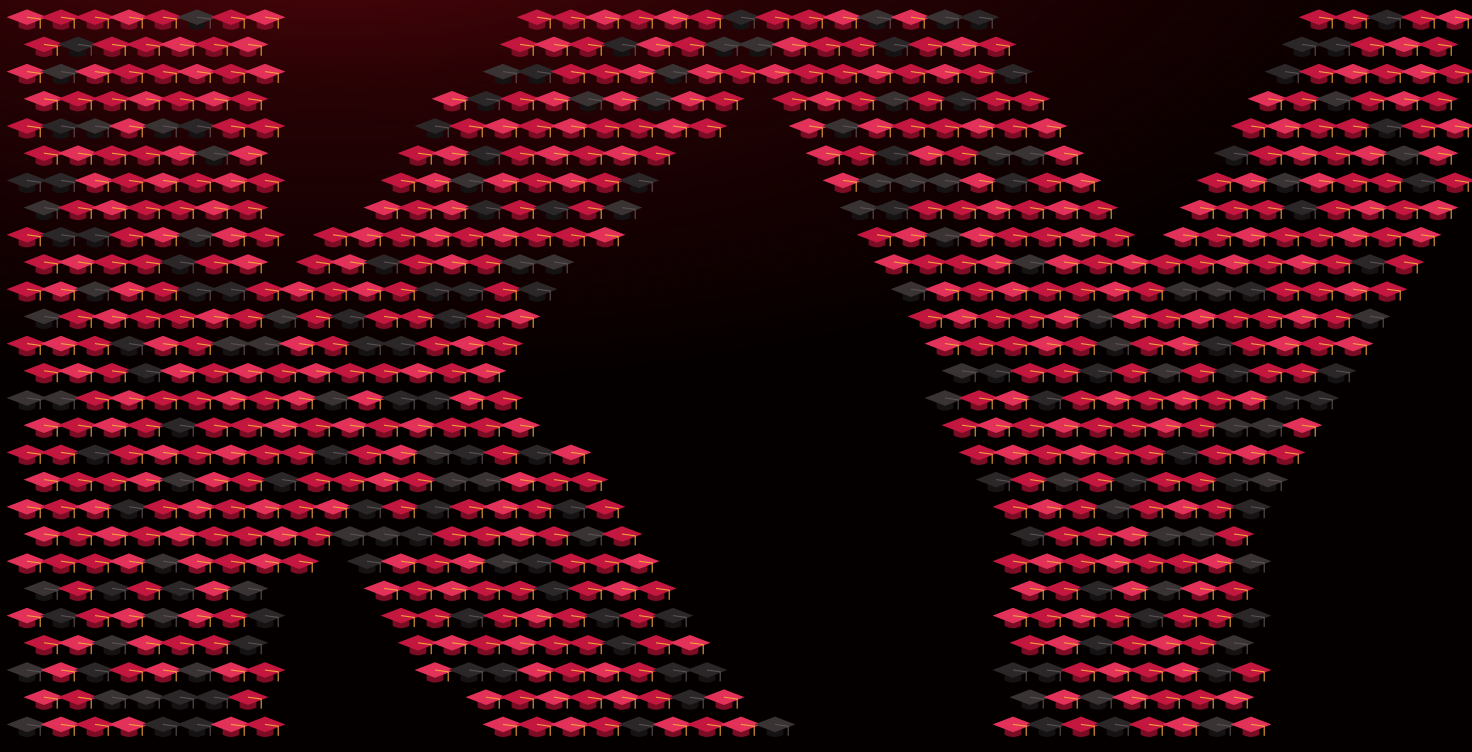
HAI Stanford University Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence

NOVEMBER 2026

The 2026 Kentucky Talent Profile

Emerson Johnston
Amy Zegart

The bright caps, **75 in every 100**, mark the international share of Kentucky's STEM master's degrees.



The 2026 Kentucky Talent Profile

By Emerson Johnston and Amy Zegart

NOVEMBER 2026

A publication jointly produced by the Hoover Institution and the Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence at Stanford University.

Table of Contents

OVERVIEW

At a Glance 6

SECTIONS

Section 1 International Dependence 8
Section 2 STEM Degrees 20
Section 3 Where Students Come From 26
Section 4 K-12 Preparation 34
Section 5 Graduate Research 36
Section 6 Do Graduates Stay? 38
Section 7 Research Funding 40
Section 8 H-1B Jobs and Green Cards 42
Section 9 STEM Workforce 46
Section 10 Patents 48
Section 11 Competitors 50
Section 12 Fields of Study 52
Section 13 Students and Money 62
Section 14 Student Outcomes 70
Section 15 Faculty 74
Section 16 Institutions 78

BACK MATTER

About these Data 82
By the Numbers 84
Sources 93

Authors

Emerson Victoria Johnston is a research assistant with the Hoover Institution's Technology Policy Accelerator. A Knight-Hennessy Scholar, she holds a master's in international policy from Stanford University, and is on leave from its master's program in the history of science, technology, environment, and medicine.

Dr. Amy Zegart is the Morris Arnold and Nona Jean Cox Senior Fellow at the Hoover Institution, director of Hoover's Technology Policy Accelerator, and a senior fellow and associate director at Stanford University's Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence.

Data come from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), the Department of Homeland Security's SEVIS by the Numbers, the National Assessment of Educational Progress, NSF's Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates and Survey of Earned Doctorates, the Department of Labor's Office of Foreign Labor Certification, the USCIS H-1B Employer Data Hub, the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and USPTO patent data via PatentsView, processed in Python; every figure and table is generated from those sources, and each one names its source.

About This Profile

This profile is a companion to *The 2026 US Talent Report: Benchmarking America's STEM Pipeline Amid the Great Talent Competition*. It applies the report's measures to Kentucky: the students the state develops at home, those it draws from abroad, and how both compare with the nation and with the states closest to it in size.

Degrees, enrollment, prices, outcomes and faculty come from IPEDS, the federal census of U.S. colleges and universities, harmonized across 1980–2025. Countries of citizenship come from SEVIS by the Numbers, the Department of Homeland Security's monthly count of active F-1 and M-1 students. Each figure names its source. Peer states are the four closest in total fall enrollment.

HOOVER INSTITUTION | Stanford University
HAI Stanford University Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence
The 2026 Kentucky Talent Profile

How to Cite this Profile

Emerson V. Johnston and Amy Zegart, “The 2026 Kentucky Talent Profile,” Technology Policy Accelerator, Hoover Institution, and the Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence, Stanford University, Stanford, CA, November 2026.

Public Data and Tools

The data behind every chart come from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), published by the National Center for Education Statistics, and from SEVIS by the Numbers, published by the Department of Homeland Security's Student and Exchange Visitor Program. An interactive version of this profile accompanies the report.

To share any charts and figures, proper attribution is required. This profile is licensed under Attribution-NoDerivatives 4.0 International (CC BY-ND 4.0). Please cite as: The 2026 Kentucky Talent Profile.

AT A GLANCE

What Kentucky's numbers say

1. **International students earn 75% of Kentucky's STEM master's degrees,** 23.2 points above the U.S. (52%) in 2025, ranking 2nd of 51 on dependence. The share is 44% for STEM research doctorates (U.S. 43%) and 4.6% for STEM bachelor's (U.S. 6.6%).
2. **Kentucky awarded 4.04K STEM master's degrees to international students in 2025,** 3.5% of the U.S. total and 9th of 51 among states. Since 2015 the count changed 13.0×, against 2.2× nationally.
3. **The heaviest dependence is in computer & info sciences,** where international students earned 84% of master's degrees (4.61K degrees; U.S. 65%). One STEM field with at least 50 master's graduates is majority-international.
4. **Among states of similar size,** Kentucky ranks 1st of 5 on the international share of STEM master's: Kentucky 75%, Alabama 43%, Tennessee 50%, Wisconsin 55%, South Carolina 39%.
5. **77% of Kentucky's first-time students in fall 2024 were state residents** and 1.6% came from abroad. More students arrived from other states (8.83K) than residents left (6.32K), a net gain of 2.51K; the top destination for those leaving was Ohio.

75%

of the STEM master's degrees Kentucky awards go to international students (U.S. 52%).

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

SCORECARD

Nine numbers against the nation

290K #25
Students enrolled, 2024
U.S. **19.7M** · +12% since 2015

4.04K #9
International STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **117K** · 12.98× since 2015

75% #2
International share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · +42.2 pp since 2015

21% #9
International share of grad students, 2024
U.S. **17%** · +13.4 pp since 2015

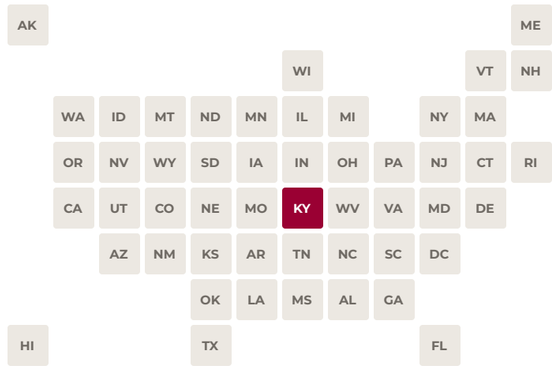
17% #49
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025
U.S. **24%** · +0.9 pp since 2015

58% #38
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · +9.3 pp since 2015

$7.45K #45
Appropriations per student, 2024
U.S. **$11.4K** · +2.1% since 2015

77% #16
First-time students from in state, 2024
U.S. **–** · −1.9 pp since 2016

$76.7K #48
Average faculty salary, 2024
U.S. **$106K** · −12% since 2016

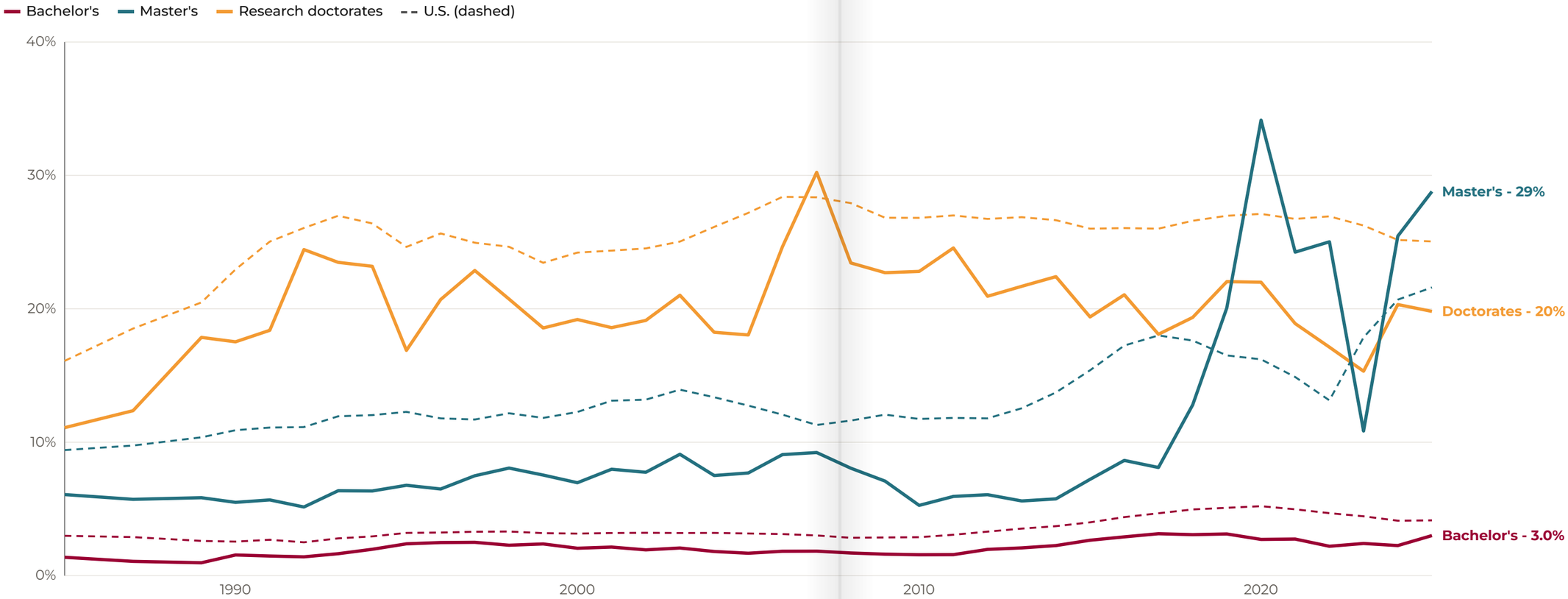


Badges give Kentucky's rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Changes are since 2015.

SECTION 1

International Dependence

Figure 1 What Share of Kentucky's Degrees Go to International Students?



International share of degrees awarded, all fields; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions, 1985–2025.

International students make up 21% of Kentucky's graduate enrollment and 1.4% of its undergraduates. Dependence climbs with each degree: 3.0% of bachelor's, 29% of master's and 20% of research doctorates go to international students.

In STEM the shares are higher still: 4.6% of STEM bachelor's, 75% of STEM master's and 44% of STEM doctorates. The state awards 3.5% of all U.S. international STEM master's, 9th of 51.

21%
Int. share of grad students, 2024
U.S. **17%** · **9th** of 51 · +13.4 pp since 2015

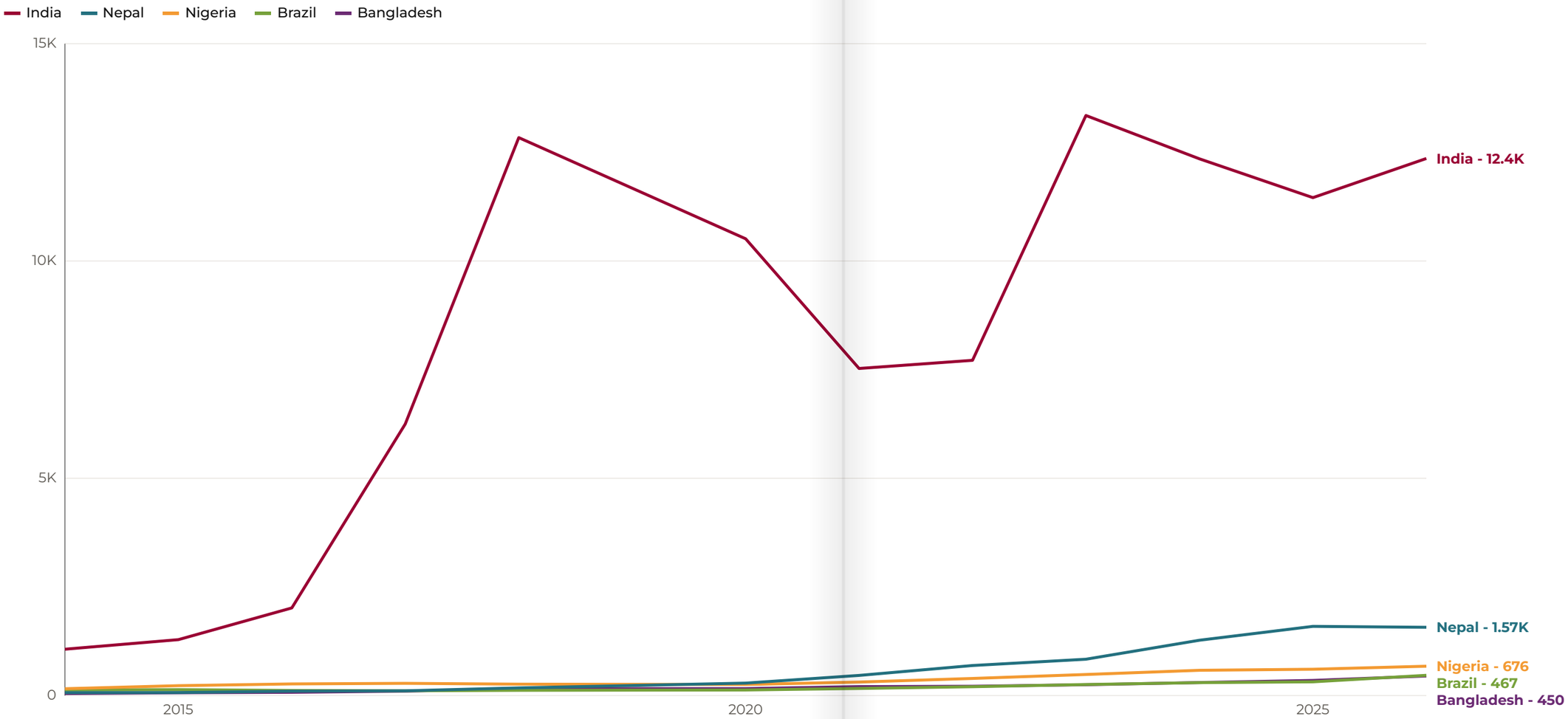
29%
Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **7th** of 51 · +21.6 pp since 2015

75%
Int. share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · **2nd** of 51 · +42.2 pp since 2015

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

Figure 2 Where Do Kentucky's International Students Come From?



Active F-1 and M-1 students by country of citizenship, the five largest in October 2026; one fall snapshot per year (the month closest to November), October 2014–October 2026. All education levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers.

In October 2026, Kentucky had 21.8K active international students in SEVIS, 18th of 51. India accounted for 57% of them and Nepal for 7.2%, against 27% and 2.9% nationally.

Students came from 173 countries, but the two largest supplied 64%. The state's total is up 167% since 2014.

21.8K
Active international students, October 2026
18th of 51 · U.S. **1.19M**

57%
From India
U.S. **27%**

19%
In STEM fields
U.S. **63%**

INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS

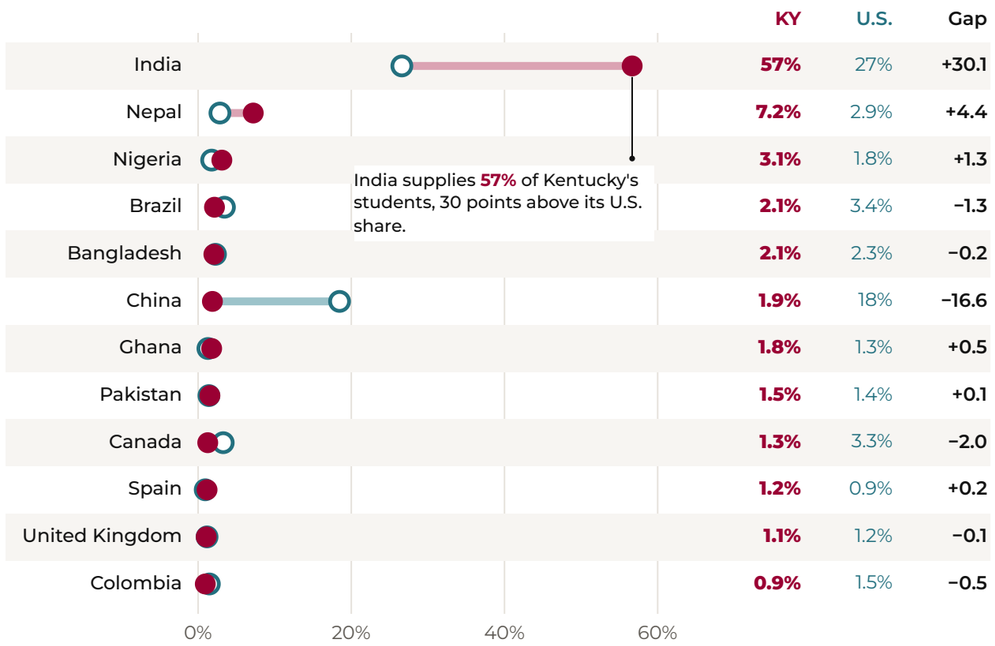
How Does Kentucky's Mix of Countries Compare With the Nation's?

In October 2026, Kentucky had **21.8K** active F-1 and M-1 students, 18th of 51 states and **1.8%** of the U.S. total. They came from 173 countries.

India supplied **57%** of them, against 27% nationally, and Nepal **7.2%**, against 2.9%. Nigeria (3.1%), Brazil (2.1%) and Bangladesh (2.1%) followed.

Together the two largest countries supplied **64%** of the state's international students (U.S. 45%), 2nd among the states, against 37% in 2015.

Figure 3 Is Kentucky's Mix of Countries Like the Nation's?



Share of active F-1 and M-1 students, all levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October 2026.

21.8K
Active international students, October 2026
18th of 51 · U.S. **1.19M**

57%
From India
U.S. **27%**

7.2%
From Nepal
U.S. **2.9%**

173
Countries represented
U.S. **219**

The state's count is up 7.7% from 2025 and up 164% since 2015, when it stood at 8.27K. Its share of all U.S. international students is up 1.1 points since 2015, to **1.8%**.

Since 2015, students from India went from 1.29K to 12.4K; students from Nepal went from 71 to 1.57K; students from Nigeria went from 228 to 676.

Table 1 International Students in Kentucky, 2015–2026

	2015	2025	2026	Change since 2015	U.S. 2026	Rank
ALL INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS						
Active F-1 and M-1 students	8.27K	20.2K	**21.8K**	2.64×	1.19M	18th
Share of U.S. active F-1/M-1 students	0.7%	1.6%	**1.8%**	+1.1 pp	–	18th
Countries of citizenship represented	161	171	**173**	+7.5%	219	17th
Share from the two largest countries of origin	37%	64%	**64%**	+26.5 pp	45%	2nd
LARGEST COUNTRIES OF CITIZENSHIP (STUDENTS)					**U.S. SHARE**	**STATE SHARE**
India	1.29K	11.5K	**12.4K**	+861%	27%	57%
Nepal	71	1.59K	**1.57K**	+2.11K%	2.9%	7.2%
Nigeria	228	606	**676**	+196%	1.8%	3.1%
Brazil	137	316	**467**	+241%	3.4%	2.1%
Bangladesh	64	348	**450**	+603%	2.3%	2.1%

Active F-1 and M-1 students, one fall snapshot per year (the month closest to November; 2019 has none; the latest year is October 2026). Rank among the 50 states and DC. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers.

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

Figure 4

Which Countries Supply Kentucky's International STEM Students?

4.17K of Kentucky's international students were in STEM fields in October 2026, **19%** of the total against 63% nationally, up 22% since 2015.

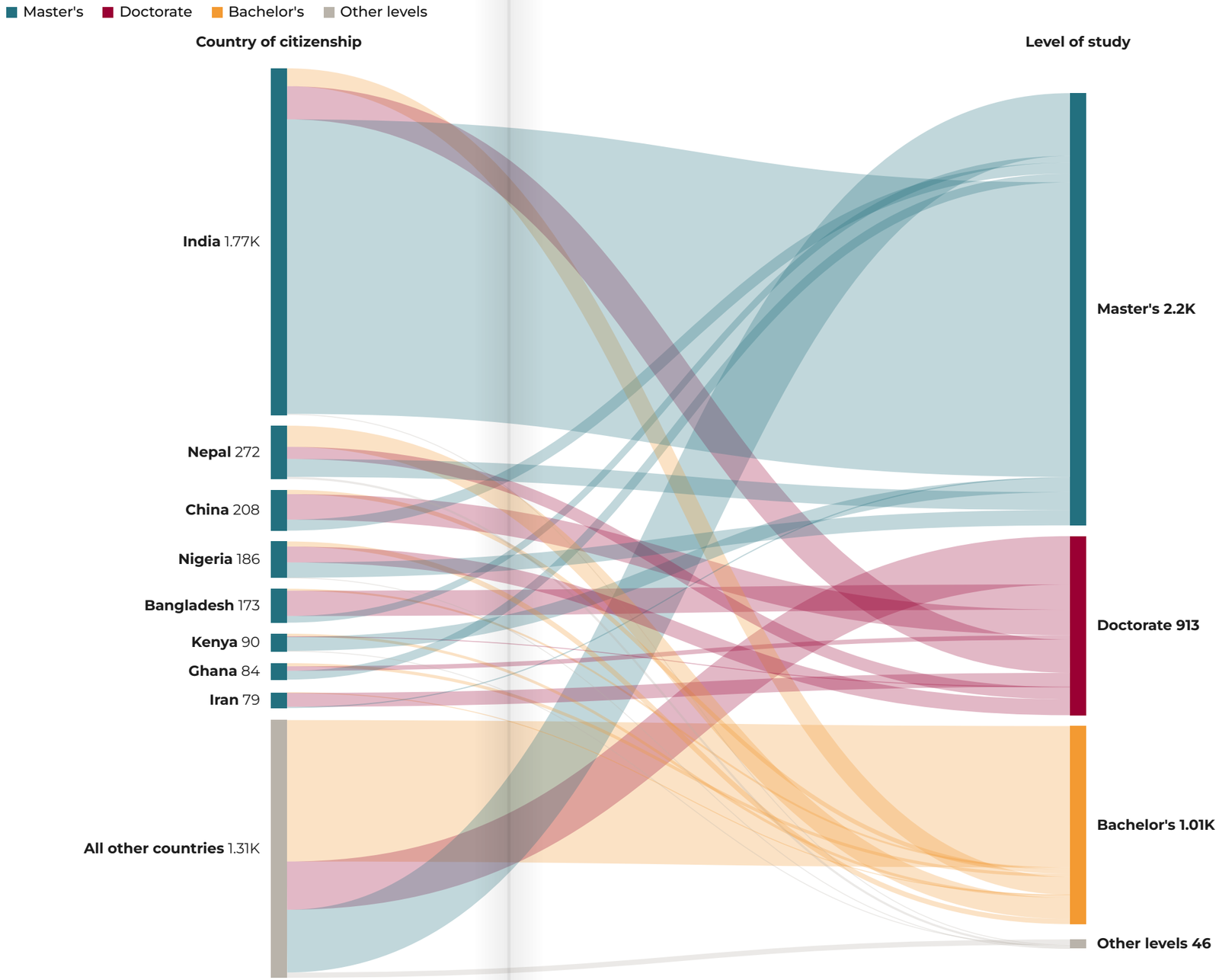
Master's students were the largest group, **2.2K**. India supplied 68% of them and Nepal 4.1%.

STEM doctoral students went from 774 in 2015 to **913**, and STEM master's students from 1.16K to 2.2K.

4.17K
Active STEM F-1/M-1 students, 2026
U.S. **749K** · **30th** of 51 · +22% since 2015

19%
Share in STEM fields
U.S. **63%**

2.2K
Active STEM master's students, 2026
U.S. **393K** · **26th** of 51 · +90% since 2015



Active F-1 and M-1 students in STEM fields by country of citizenship and level of study, October 2026; the eight largest countries are shown. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October 2026.

INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

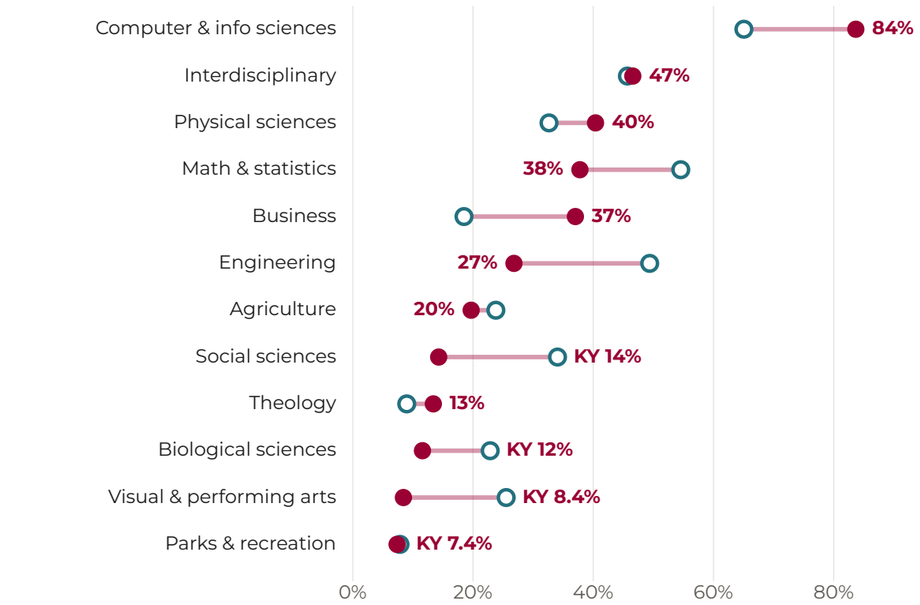
How International Are Kentucky's Master's Fields?

Each row is a master's field with at least 30 graduates in Kentucky in 2025, ranked by the share of degrees earned by international students (U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas). The filled dot is the state's share; the open dot is the national share for the same field.

Highest international shares. Computer & info sciences 84% (U.S. 65%); interdisciplinary 47% (U.S. 46%); physical sciences 40% (U.S. 33%).

All master's degrees. 29% in 2025 (U.S. 22%; 7th of 51 states), up 3.3 points from 25% in 2024, and up 21.6 points since 2015 (7.2%).

Figure 5 Which Master's Fields Depend Most on International Students?



International share of master's degrees by field, 2025; fields with 30+ graduates. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

29%
Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **7th** of 51

75%
Int. share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · **2nd** of 51

84%
Int. share of CS master's, 2025
U.S. **65%** · **8th** of 47

The table gives the international share of degrees in each STEM field at three levels: Kentucky first, the United States after the slash. The master's column is highlighted. A dash means the state awarded no degrees in the field at that level.

Highest international share among STEM master's fields. Computer & info sciences, 84% (U.S. 65%).

STEM fields where international students earn a majority of master's degrees. 1.

Table 2 How International Is Each STEM Field?

Field	Bachelor's	Master's	Doctorates
Computer & info sciences	10.0% / 8.6%	**84% / 65%**	52% / 56%
Engineering	3.4% / 7.2%	**27% / 49%**	56% / 55%
Engineering technology	2.3% / 4.5%	**7.2% / 54%**	– / 42%
Math & statistics	3.4% / 17%	**38% / 55%**	– / 53%
Physical sciences	4.5% / 6.0%	**40% / 33%**	45% / 38%
Biological sciences	2.7% / 3.4%	**12% / 23%**	16% / 23%
Natural resources	1.5% / 2.0%	**55% / 17%**	– / 27%
Architecture	2.5% / 7.3%	**3.6% / 29%**	– / 55%

International share in Kentucky / U.S., 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

How Has Kentucky's STEM Master's Output Grown?

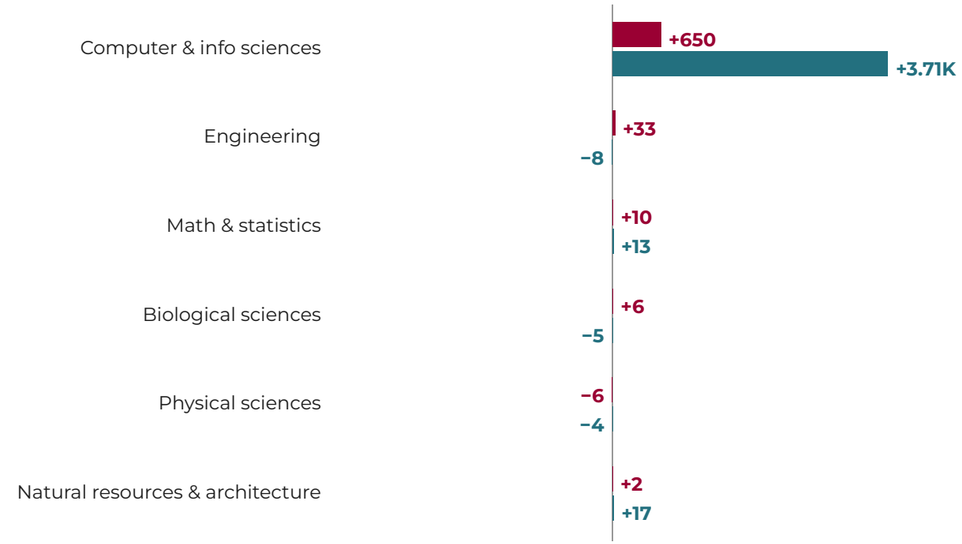
Each pair of bars is the change in the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in Kentucky between 2015 and 2025 in one field: to domestic students (U.S. citizens and permanent residents) and to international students. Bars to the left of the axis are declines.

STEM master's degrees. 5.36K in 2025, against 941 in 2015: +3.73K for international students and +695 for domestic students.

Computer & info sciences. +650 for domestic students and +3.71K for international students.

Engineering. +33 for domestic students and −8 for international students.

Figure 6 Where Did the STEM Master's Growth Come From?



Change in STEM master's degrees by field, 2015–2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

4.04K
International STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **117K** · **9th** of 51

27%
STEM share of master's, 2025
U.S. **23%** · **9th** of 51

3.5%
Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025
9th of 51

16.9
STEM master's per doctorate, 2025
U.S. **6.4** · **2nd** of 51

The table gives the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in Kentucky in each field in 2015 and 2025, the change between the two years, the number awarded to international students in 2025, and international students' share of the field's degrees in each year.

STEM share of master's degrees. 27% in 2025 (U.S. 23%; 9th of 51 states), up 4.2 points from 23% in 2024, and up 17.4 points since 2015 (9.8%).

Table 3 How Many STEM Master's Degrees Does Each Field Award?

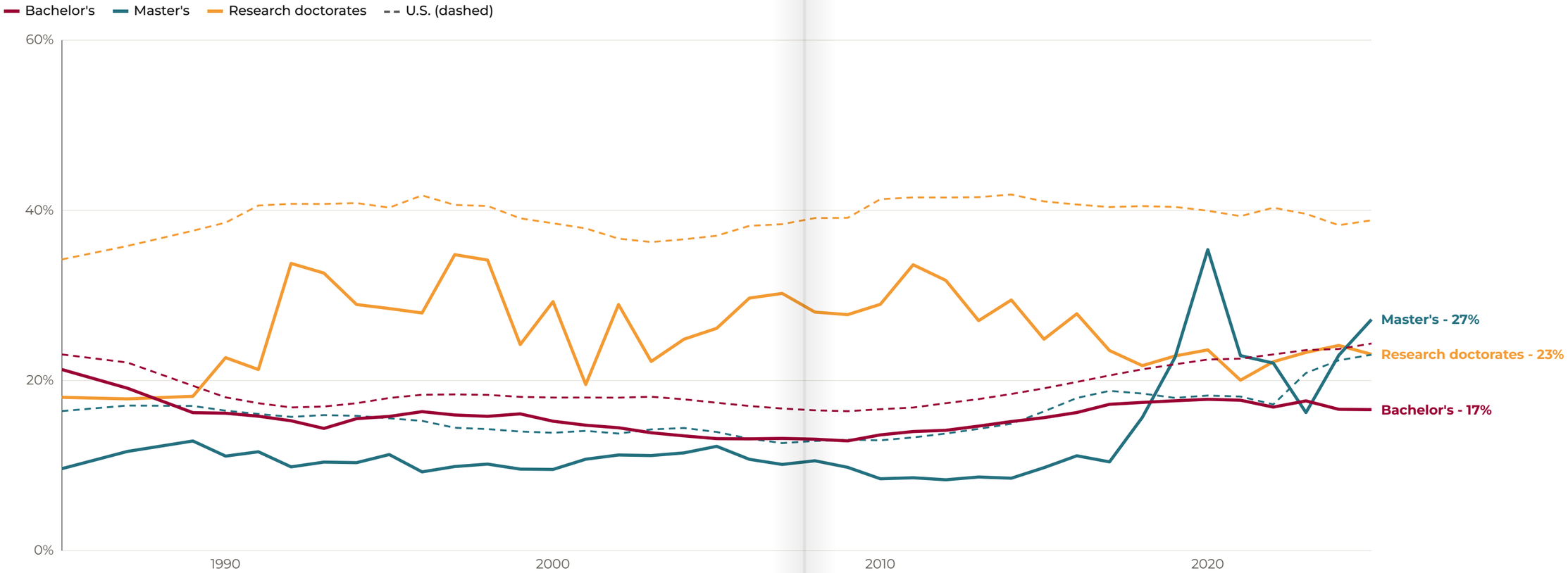
Field	2015	2025	Change	International 2025	Int. share 2015	Int. share 2025
Computer & info sciences	244	**4.61K**	+1.79K%	3.85K	58%	84%
Engineering	389	**414**	+6.4%	92	26%	22%
Math & statistics	67	**90**	+34%	34	31%	38%
Biological sciences	137	**138**	+0.7%	16	15%	12%
Physical sciences	62	**52**	−16%	21	40%	40%
Natural resources & architecture	42	**61**	+45%	19	4.8%	31%

STEM master's degrees awarded in Kentucky, all students and international students, 2015 and 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

SECTION 2

STEM Degrees

Figure 7 How Much of Kentucky's Degree Output Is STEM?



STEM share of degrees by level; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

STEM fields account for 17% of Kentucky's bachelor's degrees, 27% of its master's and 23% of its research doctorates (U.S. 24%, 23% and 39%).

The STEM share of master's degrees is up 17.4 points since 2015, and the state ranks 9th of 51 on it. On the STEM share of bachelor's degrees it ranks 49th of 51.

17%
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025
U.S. **24%** · **49th** of 51 · +0.9 pp since 2015

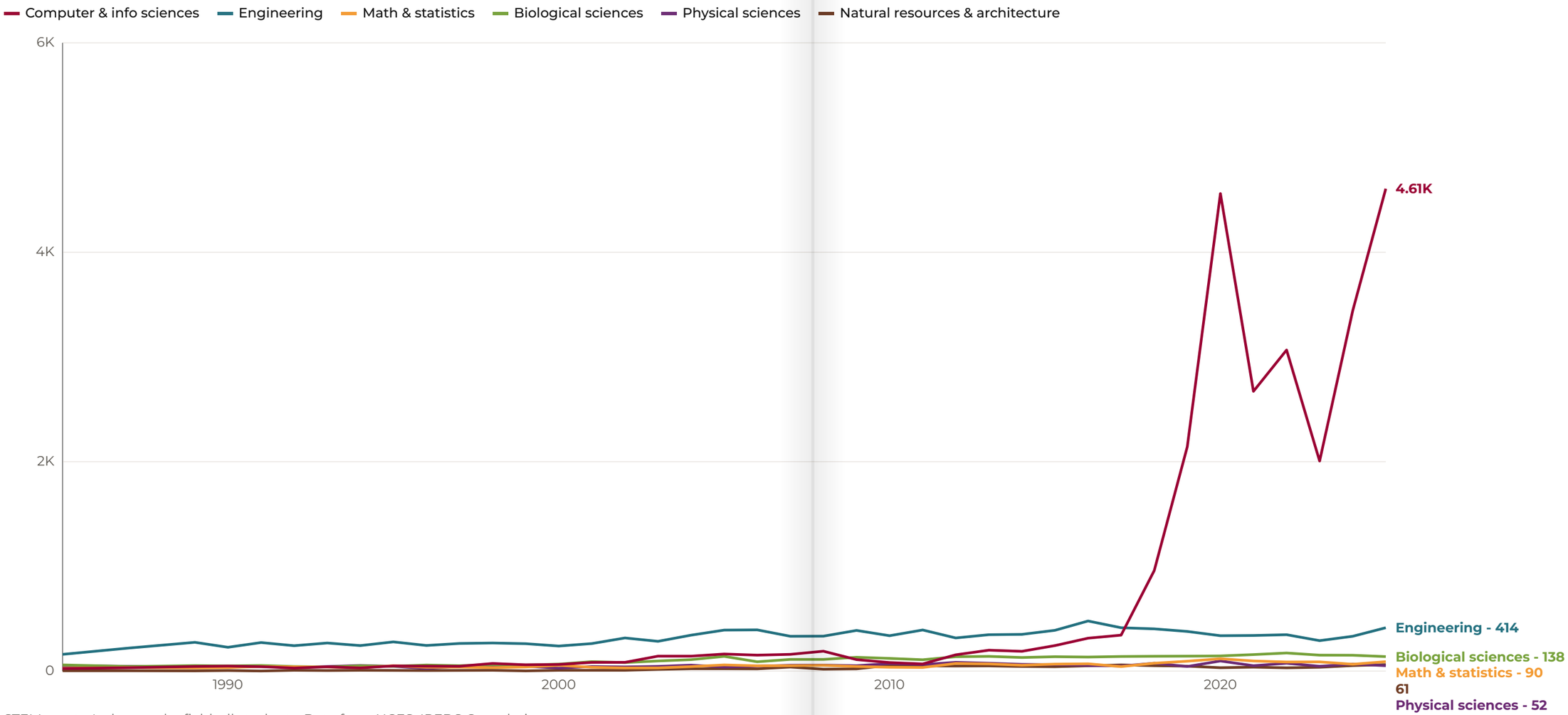
27%
STEM share of master's, 2025
U.S. **23%** · **9th** of 51 · +17.4 pp since 2015

23%
STEM share of research doctorates, 2025
U.S. **39%** · **47th** of 51 · −1.8 pp since 2015

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

Figure 8 Which STEM Fields Produce Kentucky's Master's Degrees?



STEM master's degrees by field, all students. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Computer & info sciences produced the most STEM master's degrees in 2025, 4.61K, followed by engineering (414) and biological sciences (138). Master's degrees in computer & info sciences are up 1.79K% since 2015.

International students earned 4.04K of the state's STEM master's degrees in 2025, 3.5% of the national total (9th of 51).

4.04K

International STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **117K** · **9th** of 51 · 12.98× since 2015

3.5%

Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025

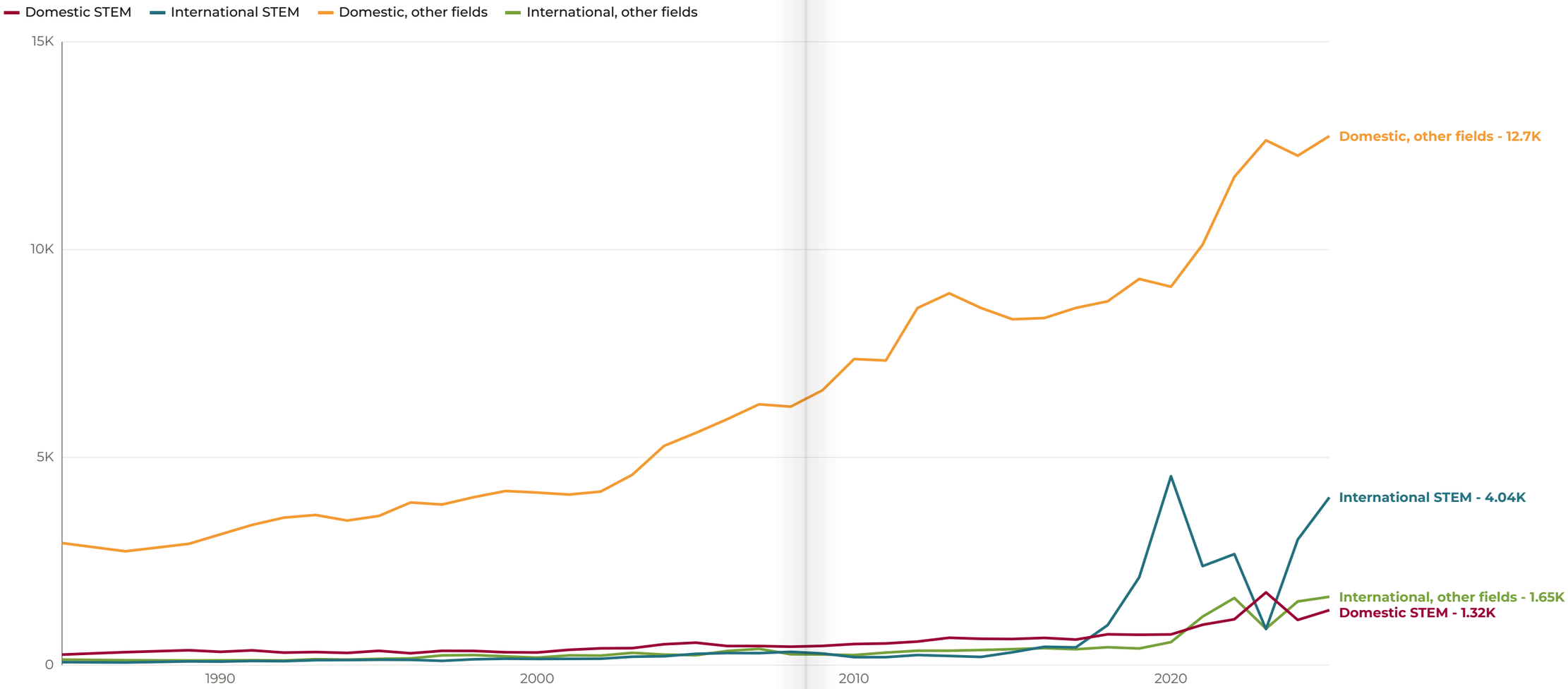
· **9th** of 51 · +2.9 pp since 2015

84%

Int. share of CS master's, 2025

U.S. **65%** · **8th** of 47 · +25.5 pp since 2015

Figure 9 Who Earns Kentucky's Master's Degrees?



Master's degrees by student residency and field group. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Between 2015 and 2025, 3.73K more STEM master's degrees went to international students and 695 more to domestic students.

International students earn 75% of Kentucky's STEM master's but 11% of master's in other fields (U.S. 52% and 12%).

29%
Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **7th** of 51 · +21.6 pp since 2015

75%
Int. share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · **2nd** of 51 · +42.2 pp since 2015

16.9
STEM master's per doctorate, 2025
U.S. **6.4** · **2nd** of 51 · +12.3 since 2015

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

SECTION 3

Where Students Come From

Figure 10 First-Time Students by Home and Destination, Fall 2024



Home of first-time degree-seeking undergraduates (left) and the state of the institution entered (right); the five largest sources and destinations, the rest grouped. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

31.5K residents stayed in Kentucky for college in fall 2024; 8.83K students arrived from other states and 655 from abroad, while 6.32K residents left.

Each band runs from a student's home on the left to the state where they enrolled on the right. 77% of the state's first-time students are residents (U.S. –).

77%

First-time students from in state, 2024

· **16th** of 51 · −1.9 pp since 2016

1.6%

First-time students from abroad, 2024

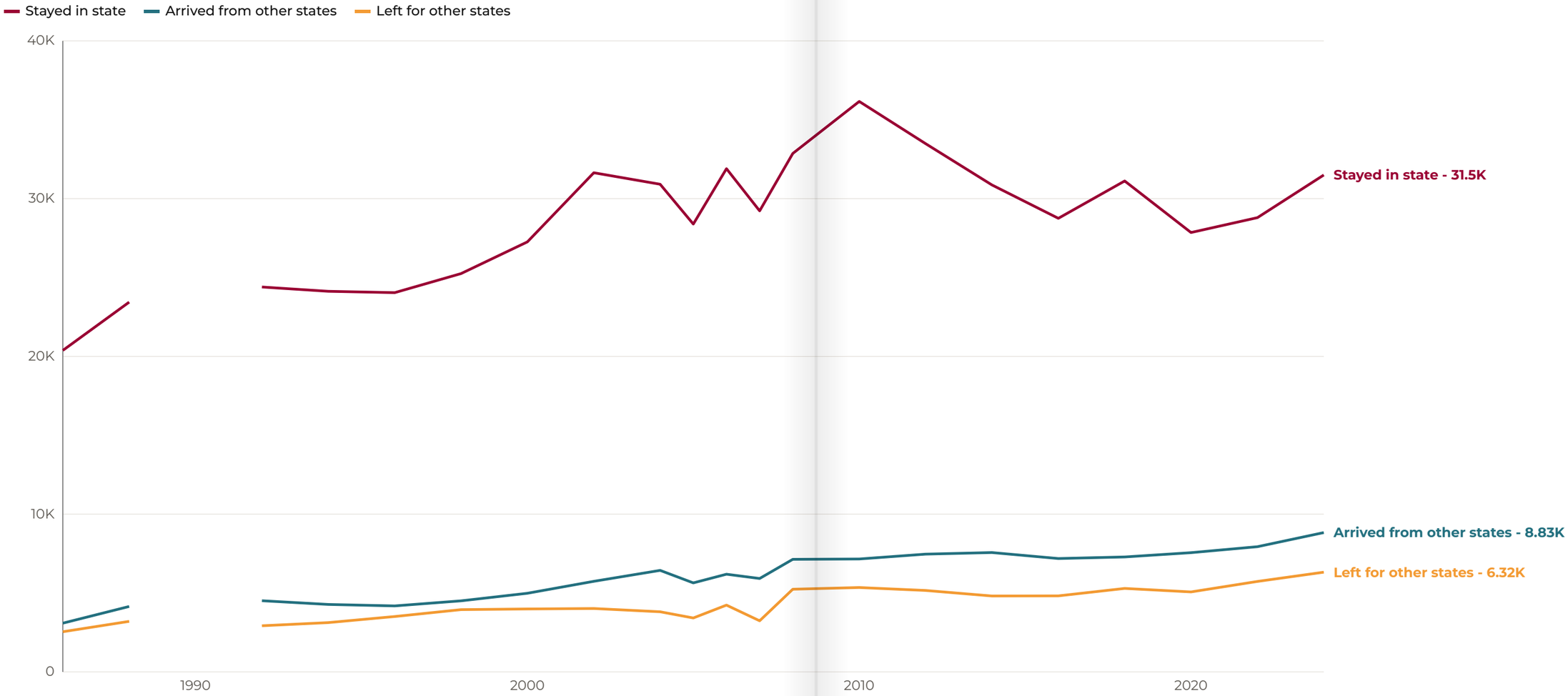
U.S. **3.1%** · **40th** of 51 · +0.2 pp since 2016

+7

Net migration per 100 residents, 2024

· **24th** of 51 · −0.4 since 2016

Figure 11 How Have the Flows Changed?



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by flow; even years before 2001. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

Since 2015, the number of residents staying in state for college is up 10%, arrivals from other states are up 23%, and residents leaving are up 31%.

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

Net migration was +7 per 100 resident first-time students (24th of 51). The top destination for residents who left was Ohio (1.35K).

Figure 12

Where Do Kentucky's Newcomers Come From?

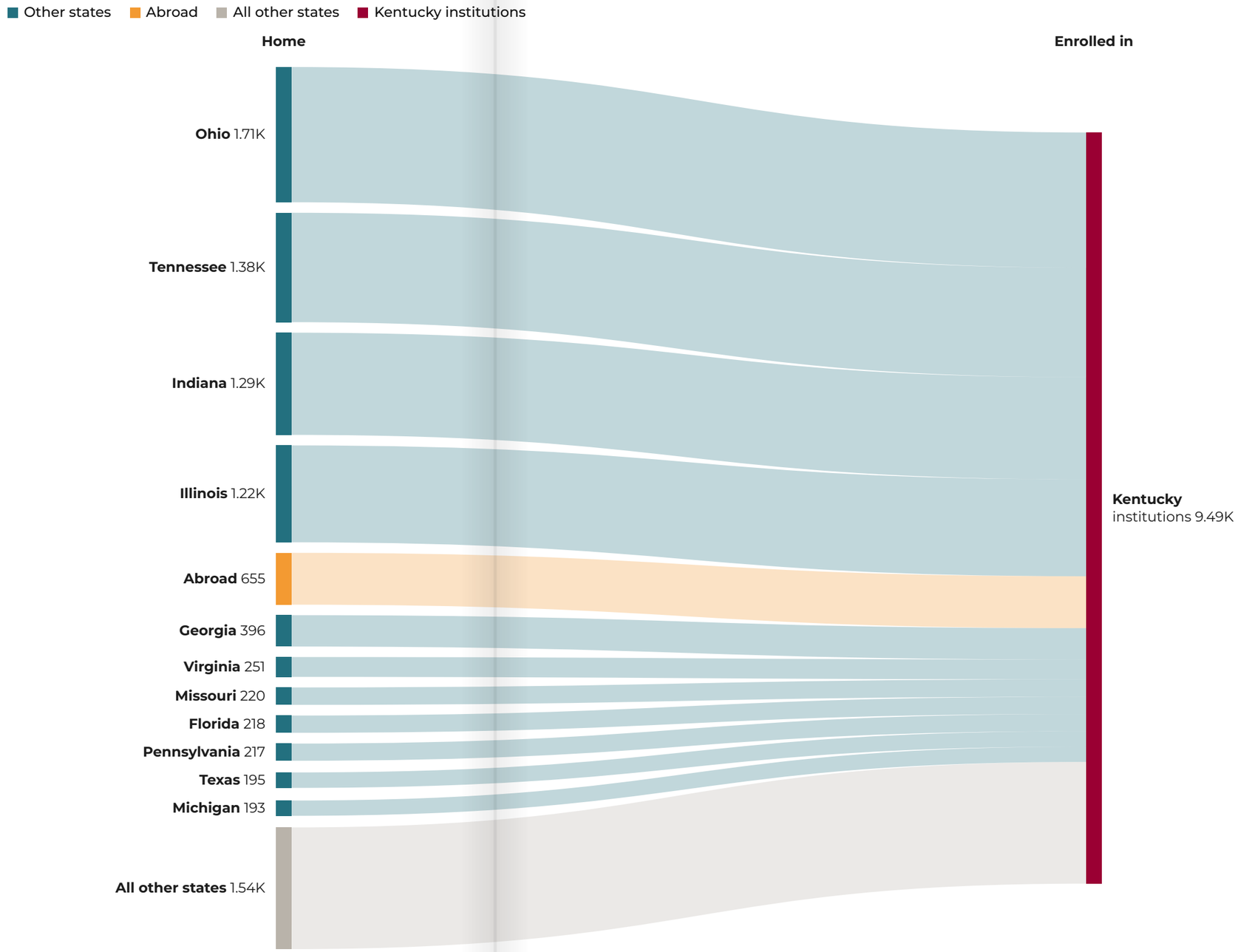
The bands show where first-time degree-seeking undergraduates who enrolled at Kentucky's institutions in fall 2024 but did not live in the state came from: the 12 largest home states and students from abroad, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Home is the state where the student lived when admitted.

Students arriving from other states. 8.83K in fall 2024, up 11% from 7.94K in fall 2022, and up 23% since fall 2016 (7.18K).

9.49K
First-time students from other states and abroad, fall 2024
Abroad **655**

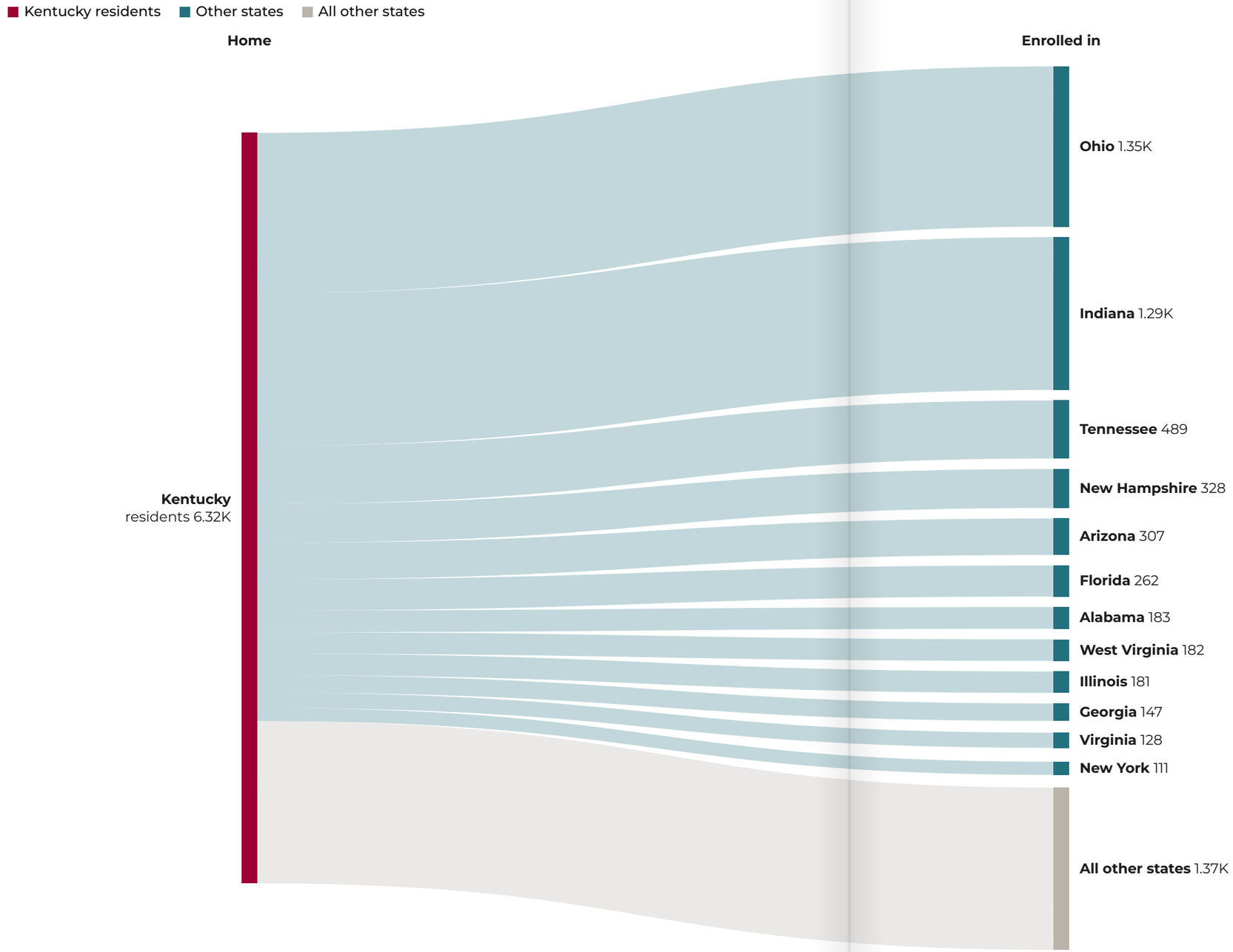
1.6%
First-time students from abroad, 2024
U.S. **3.1%** · **40th** of 51 · +0.2 pp since 2016

77%
First-time students from in state, 2024
16th of 51 · −1.9 pp since 2016



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flows. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flows. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

Figure 13

Where Do Kentucky's Residents Go When They Leave?

The bands show where Kentucky residents who left the state to start college in fall 2024 enrolled: the 12 largest destination states, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Residents who enrolled in the state are not shown.

Residents leaving for other states. 6.32K in fall 2024, up 10% from 5.73K in fall 2022, and up 31% since fall 2016 (4.82K).

Residents staying in the state. 31.5K in fall 2024, up 9.4% from 28.8K in fall 2022, and up 9.6% since fall 2016 (28.8K).

6.32K
Residents who started college in another state, fall 2024
Arrivals **9.49K**

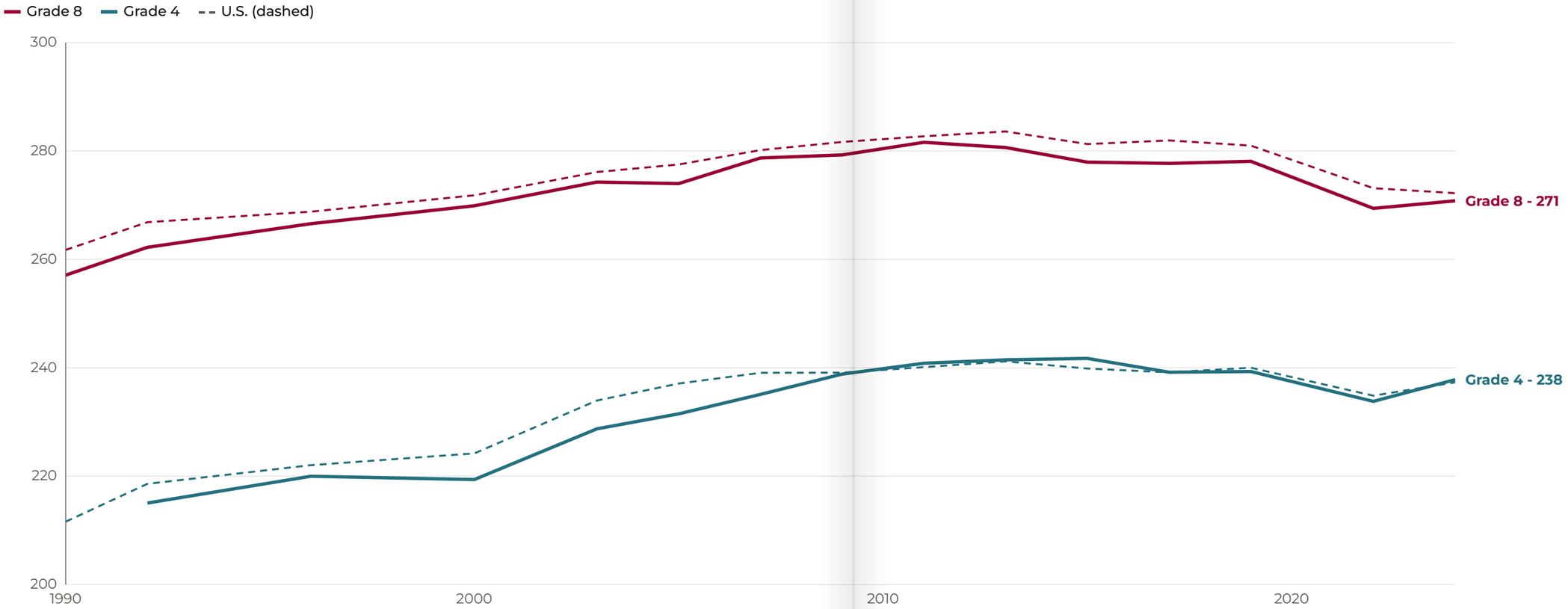
+7
Net migration per 100 residents, 2024
24th of 51 · −0.4 since 2016

1.35K
Went to Ohio
The largest destination

SECTION 4

K-12 Preparation

Figure 14 How Well Prepared in Mathematics Are Kentucky's Students?



Average NAEP mathematics score, public schools, 0–500 scale; state solid, U.S. public schools dashed. Data from NCES, National Assessment of Educational Progress.

The talent pipeline starts in school. Kentucky's eighth graders averaged 271 in mathematics on the 2024 NAEP, against 272 for U.S. public schools, 28th of 51 among the states.

24% scored at or above the Proficient level (U.S. 27%). Differences of a point or two are often within the margin of error.

271

Grade 8 math score (NAEP), 2024

U.S. **272** · **28th** of 51 · −7.1 since 2015

24%

Grade 8 math, at or above Proficient, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **32nd** of 51 · −3.3 pp since 2015

258

Grade 8 reading score (NAEP), 2024

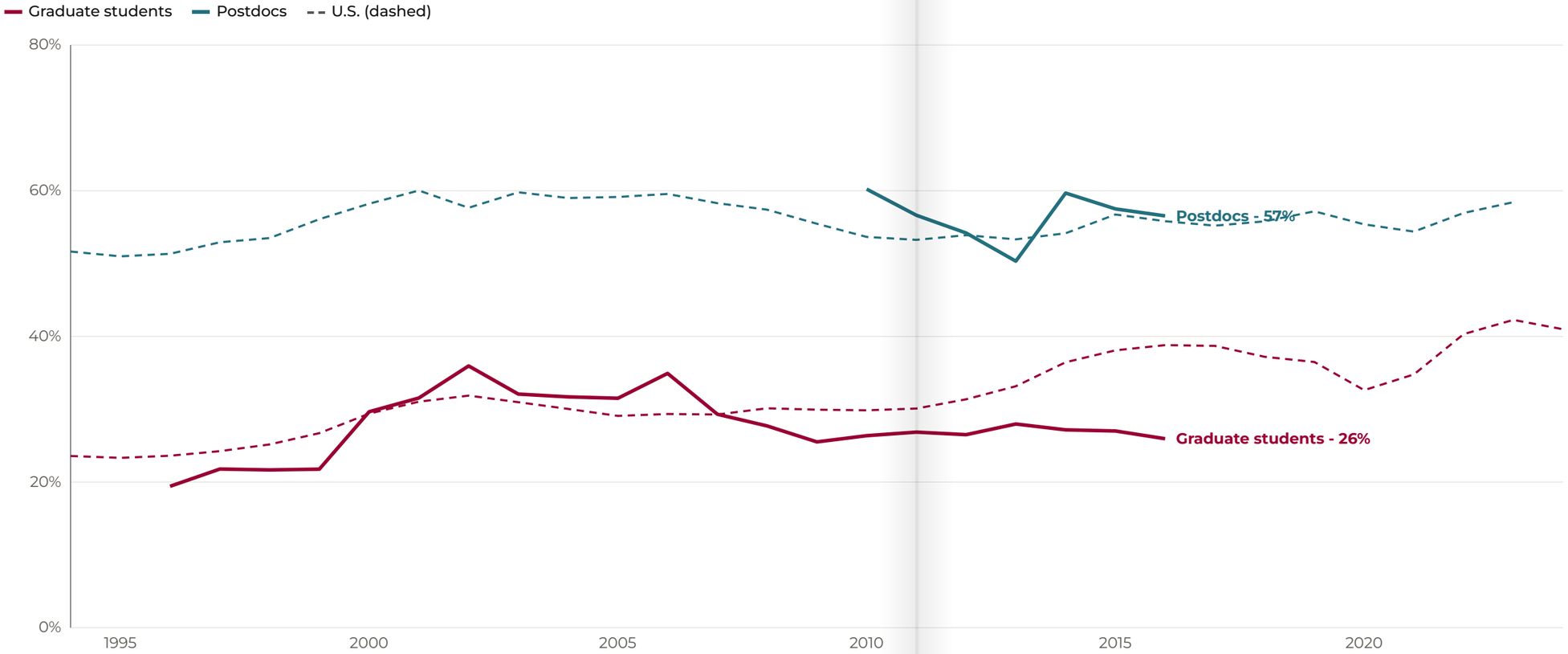
U.S. **257** · **22nd** of 51 · −9.8 since 2015

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

SECTION 5

Graduate Research

Figure 15 How Many of Kentucky's Science and Engineering Graduate Students Hold Temporary Visas?



Temporary-visa share of science and engineering graduate students and postdoctoral appointees, by the institution's state; state solid, U.S. dashed. NSF stopped publishing state tables after 2016. Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates.

In 2016, the last year NSF published state tables, 26% of Kentucky's science and engineering graduate students held temporary visas (U.S. 39%; 41st of 51).

Among postdoctoral researchers, the share was 57% (U.S. 56%). Postdocs are the stage of research training most dependent on international talent, and IPEDS does not count them.

The state's institutions awarded 455 research doctorates in 2025, 0.8% of the U.S. total (Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Earned Doctorates; NSF publishes doctorates by citizenship only for the nation).

26%

S&E grad students on temporary visas, 2016

U.S. **39%** · **41st** of 51 · −1.1 pp since 2015

57%

S&E postdocs on temporary visas, 2016

U.S. **56%** · **24th** of 51 · −1.0 pp since 2015

455

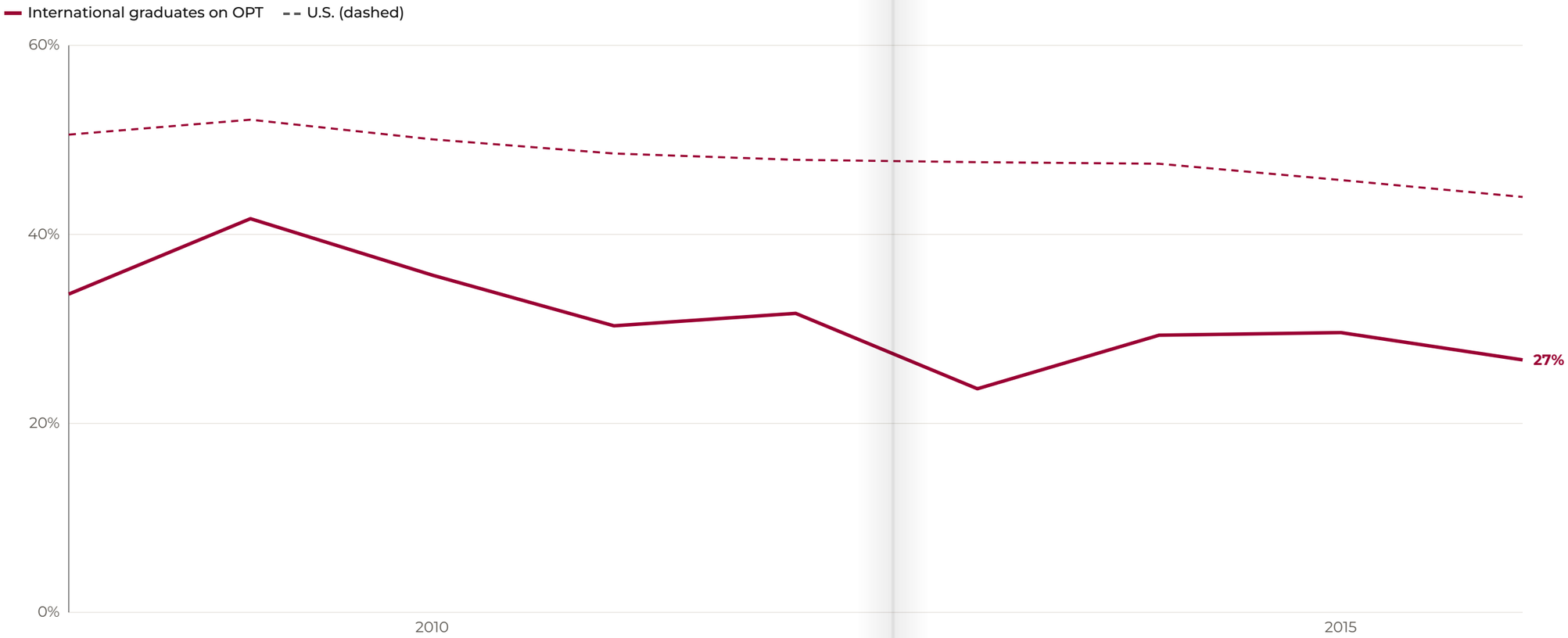
Research doctorates awarded (NSF SED), 2025

U.S. **59K** · **34th** of 51 · −9.5% since 2015

SECTION 6

Do Graduates Stay?

Figure 16 How Many of Kentucky's Graduates Go On to Work in the State?



Share of employed graduates working in the state of their institution, by graduating cohort (Data from U.S. Census Bureau, Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes; participating institutions only); international graduates' OPT jobs in the state where they studied (Data from ICE, SEVIS FOIA releases; shares only, the file is truncated). State solid, U.S. or participating states dashed.

Kentucky's institutions do not take part in the Census Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes program, so in-state employment of its graduates is not published.

Among international graduates on Optional Practical Training in 2016, 27% worked in the state where they studied (U.S. 44%). Through migration between states, the state gained 4.6 bachelor's-plus adults per 1,000 such residents in 2025 (Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey).

27%

OPT graduates working in the state, 2016

U.S. **44%** · **37th** of 51 · −2.9 pp since 2015

+4.6

Net migration, bachelor's-plus, per 1,000, 2025

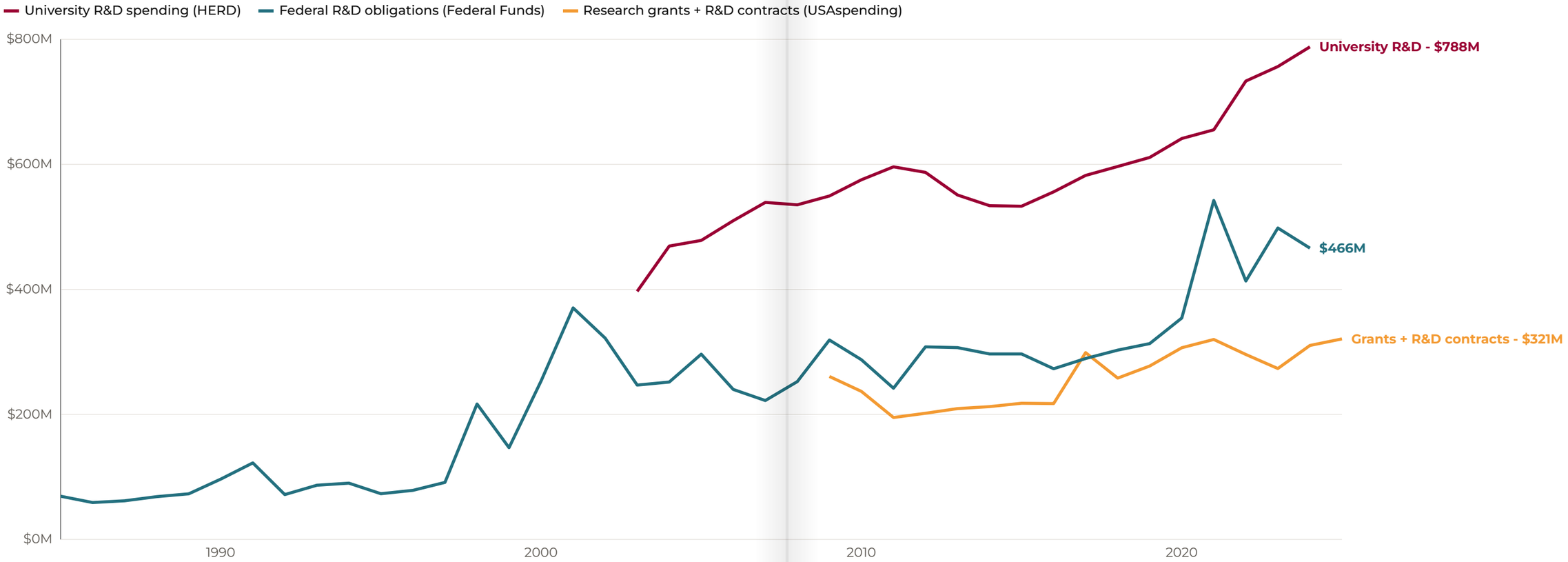
· **15th** of 51 · +8.8 since 2015

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

SECTION 7

Research Funding

Figure 17 How Much Research Money Flows Into Kentucky?



Millions of nominal dollars, fiscal years. University R&D: Data from NSF NCSES, Higher Education Research and Development Survey (FY2003-09 predecessor survey). Federal R&D obligations by state of performance: Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Federal Funds for R&D (coverage widens in FY2021). Grants from NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science plus R&D contracts: Data from USAspending.gov.

Kentucky's universities spent $788M on research and development in FY2024, 33rd of 51 among the states; 48% of it was federally funded (U.S. 55%).

Federal agencies obligated $466M for R&D performed in the state in FY2024. Research funding drives demand for graduate students and postdocs, the stage of training most dependent on international talent.

$788M
University R&D spending, 2024
U.S. **$118B** · **33rd** of 51 · +48% since 2015

48%
Federal share of university R&D, 2024
U.S. **55%** · **35th** of 51 · +5.9 pp since 2015

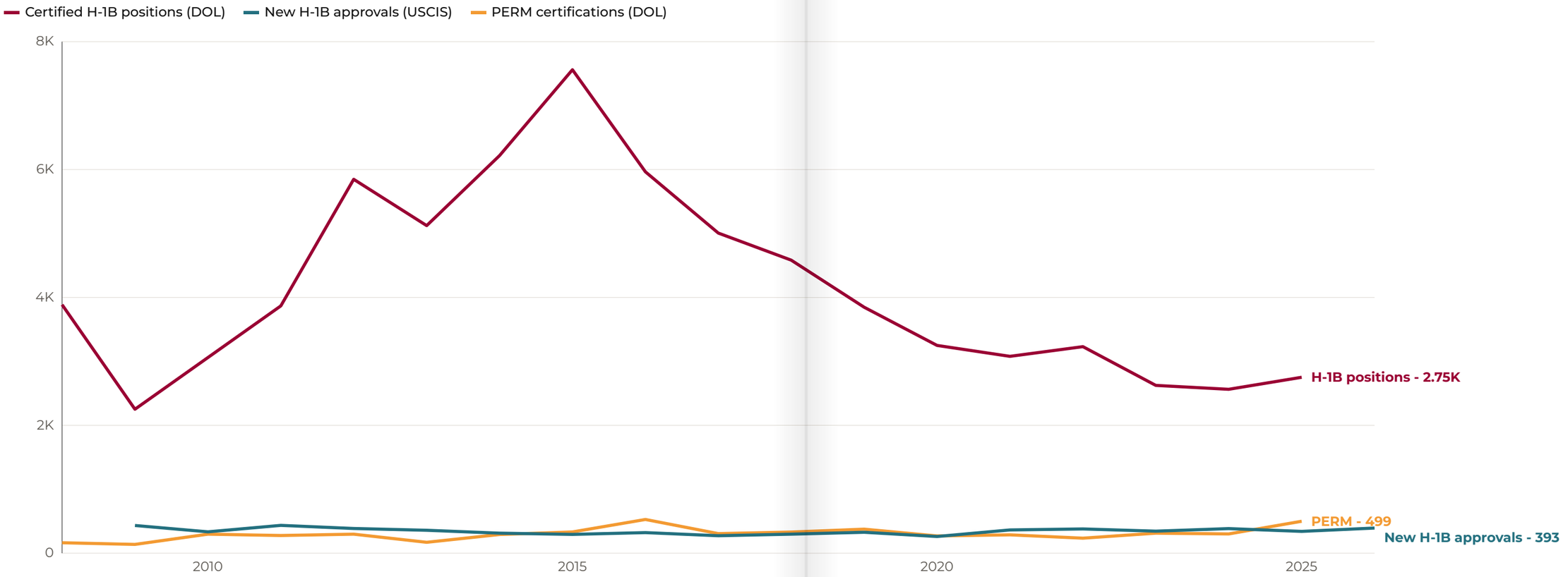
$466M
Federal R&D obligations, 2024
U.S. **$193B** · **40th** of 51 · +57% since 2015

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

SECTION 8

H-1B Jobs and Green Cards

Figure 18 How Many Skilled-Visa Jobs and Green-Card Certifications Does Kentucky Generate?



Certified H-1B positions on labor condition applications by worksite and certified PERM green-card applications, by fiscal year (Data from DOL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification); new H-1B petition approvals by the employer's address (Data from USCIS, H-1B Employer Data Hub).

Employers were certified for 2.75K H-1B positions at Kentucky worksites in FY2025, 33rd of 51 among the states. A labor certification comes before the petition, so this overstates hires; USCIS approved 393 new H-1B petitions from employers in the state in FY2026.

DOL certified 499 PERM applications, the employer's step toward an employment-based green card, for jobs in the state in FY2025. In FY2024, 4.5% were for workers still on F-1 student visas (U.S. 8.7%): the most direct link from classroom to permanent residence.

2.75K

Certified H-1B positions (worksite), 2025

U.S. **914K** · **33rd** of 51 · −64% since 2015

499

PERM green-card certifications, 2025

U.S. **138K** · **35th** of 51 · +50% since 2015

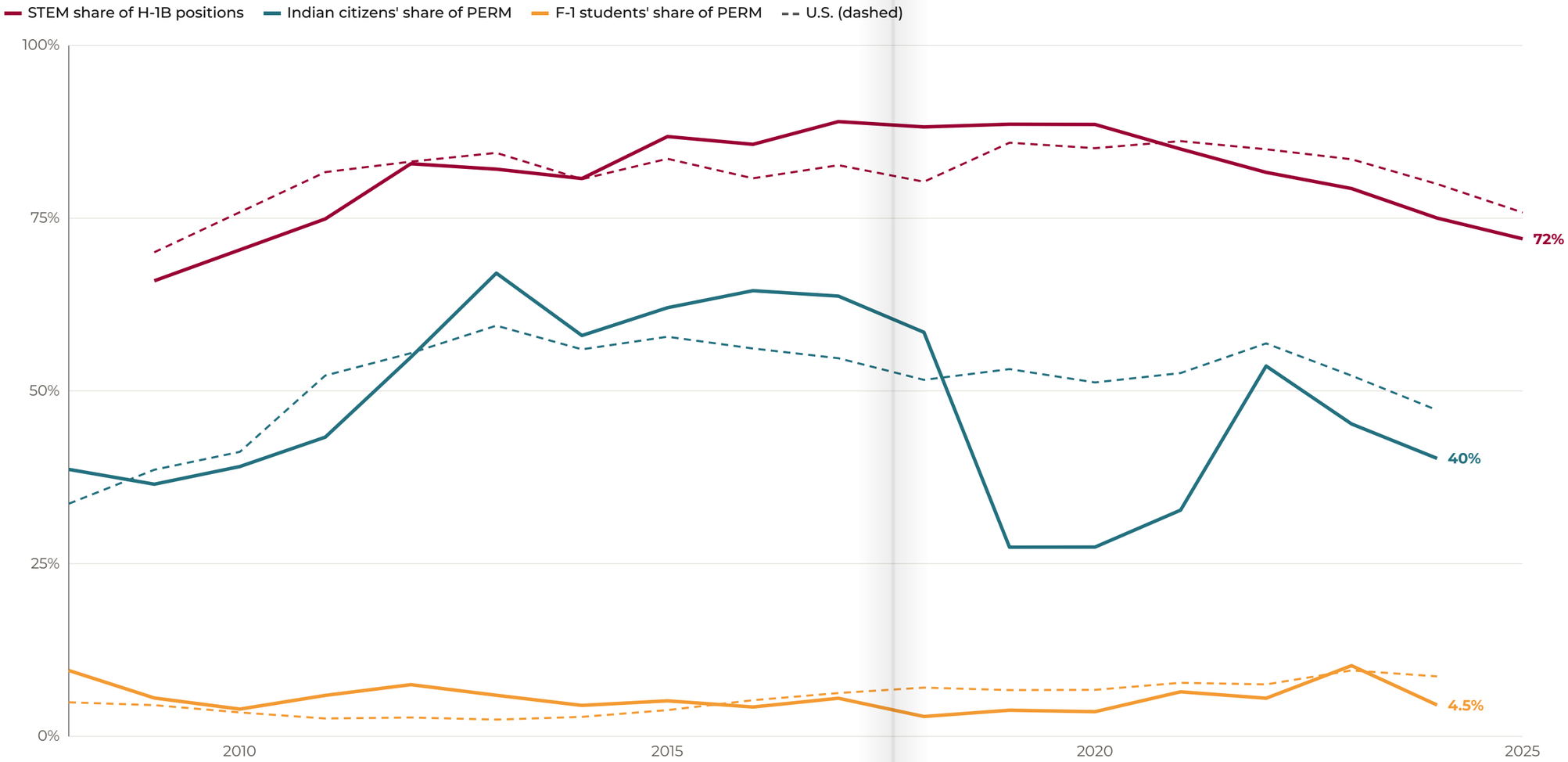
4.5%

PERM workers on F-1 student visas, 2024

U.S. **8.7%** · **44th** of 51 · −0.6 pp since 2015

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

Figure 19 Who Holds Kentucky's Skilled-Visa Jobs?



State solid, U.S. dashed. PERM citizenship and class of admission are not on the form DOL uses from FY2025. Data from DOL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification.

72% of the state's certified H-1B positions were in STEM occupations in FY2025 (U.S. 76%).

Citizens of India held 40% of the state's PERM certifications in FY2024 (U.S. 47%). Under per-country caps they face the longest waits for a green card, so this share measures the state's exposure to the backlog.

72%

STEM share of H-1B positions, 2025

U.S. **76%** · **19th** of 51 · −14.8 pp since 2015

40%

PERM certifications for Indian citizens, 2024

U.S. **47%** · **22nd** of 51 · −21.8 pp since 2015

$93.6K

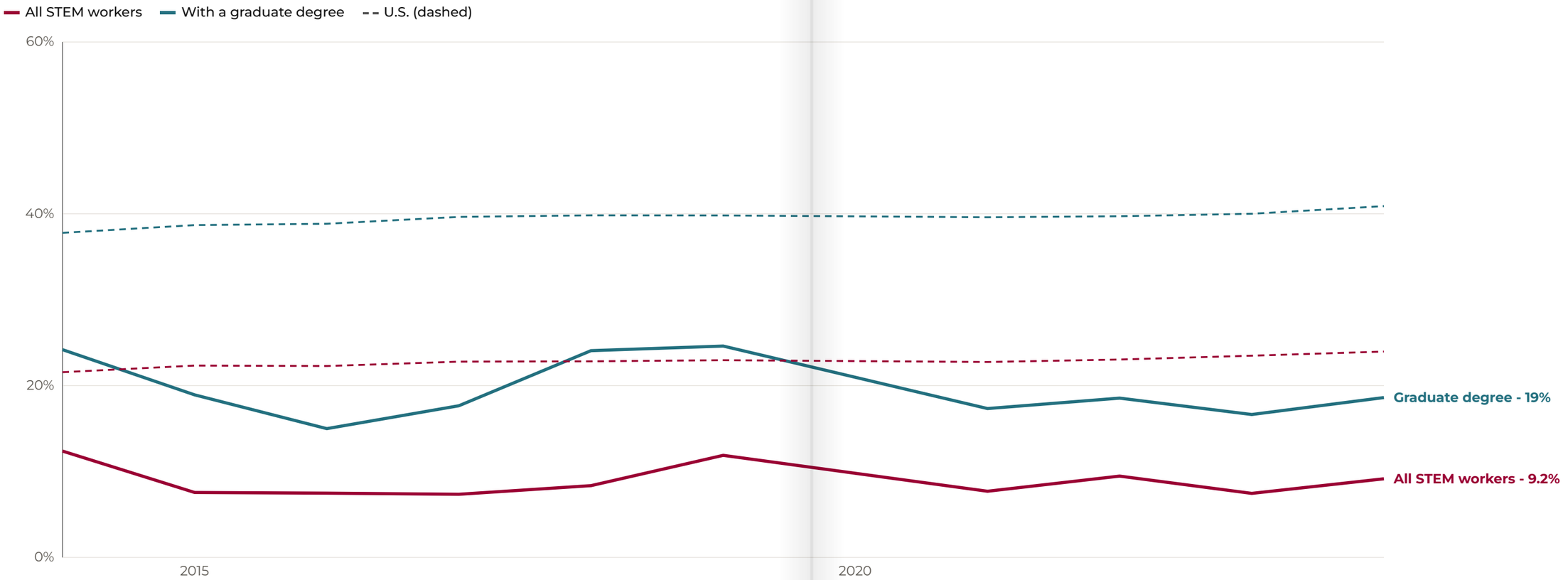
Median offered H-1B wage (nominal), 2025

U.S. **$119K** · **38th** of 51 · +43% since 2015

SECTION 9

STEM Workforce

Figure 20 How Much of Kentucky's STEM Workforce Was Born Abroad?



Foreign-born share of employed workers in STEM occupations, by state of residence; state solid, U.S. dashed. Shares resting on fewer than 100 survey records are left out. No 2020 (experimental data). Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey.

In 2024, 9.2% of the people working in STEM occupations in Kentucky were born abroad (U.S. 24%; 40th of 51).

The share rises with education: 19% of STEM workers with a graduate degree were foreign-born (U.S. 41%). 6.4% of all STEM workers were not U.S. citizens.

9.2%

Foreign-born share of STEM workers, 2024

U.S. **24%** · **40th** of 51 · +1.6 pp since 2015

19%

Foreign-born, STEM workers with grad degrees, 2024

U.S. **41%** · **41st** of 44 · −0.3 pp since 2015

6.4%

Noncitizen share of STEM workers, 2024

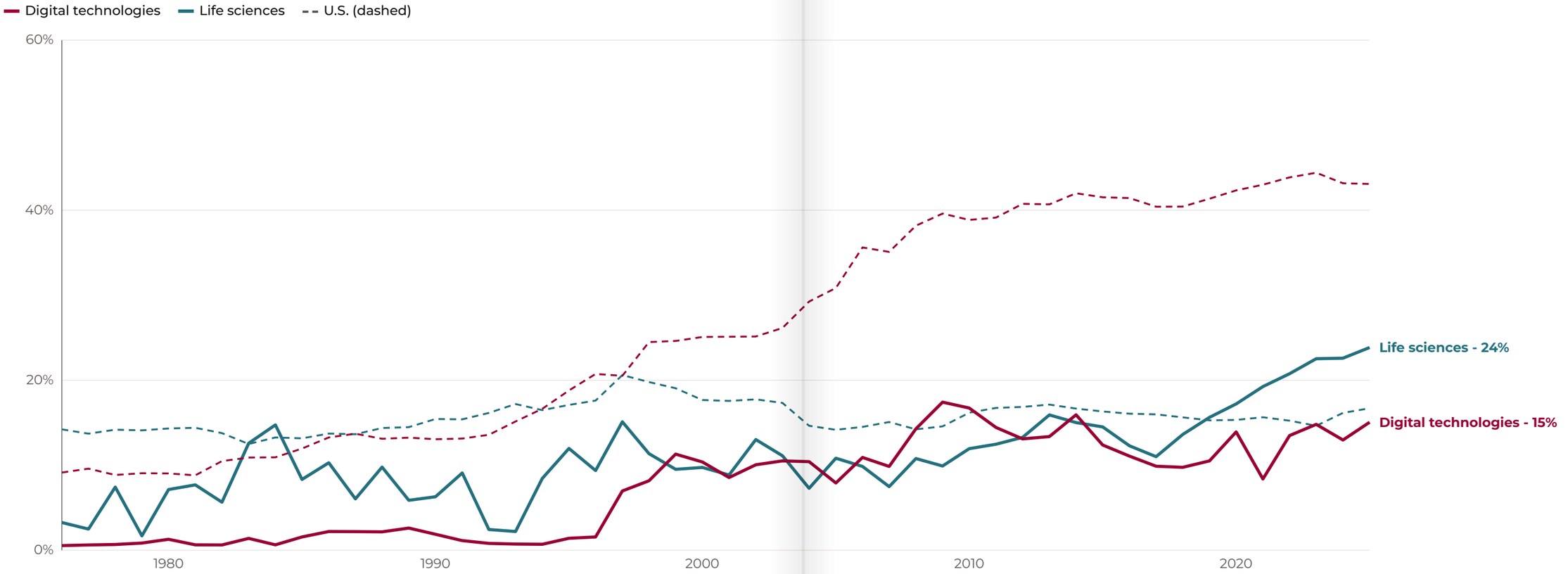
U.S. **11%** · **29th** of 51 · +1.3 pp since 2015

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

SECTION 10

Patents

Figure 21 What Kinds of Technology Does Kentucky Patent?



Share of patents granted to owners in the state, by WIPO technology field of the first classification; state solid, U.S. dashed. Fractional counts by the owner's (assignee's) location, not where inventors live. Data from USPTO, PatentsView.

Organizations and people in Kentucky were granted 229 U.S. patents in 2025, 0.2% of all patents with a U.S. owner (40th of 51).

15% were in digital technologies (U.S. 43%) and 24% in the life sciences (U.S. 17%).

229

Patents granted to owners in the state, 2025

U.S. **135K** · **40th** of 51 · −54% since 2015

15%

Patents in digital technologies, 2025

U.S. **43%** · **33rd** of 51 · +2.7 pp since 2015

24%

Patents in life sciences, 2025

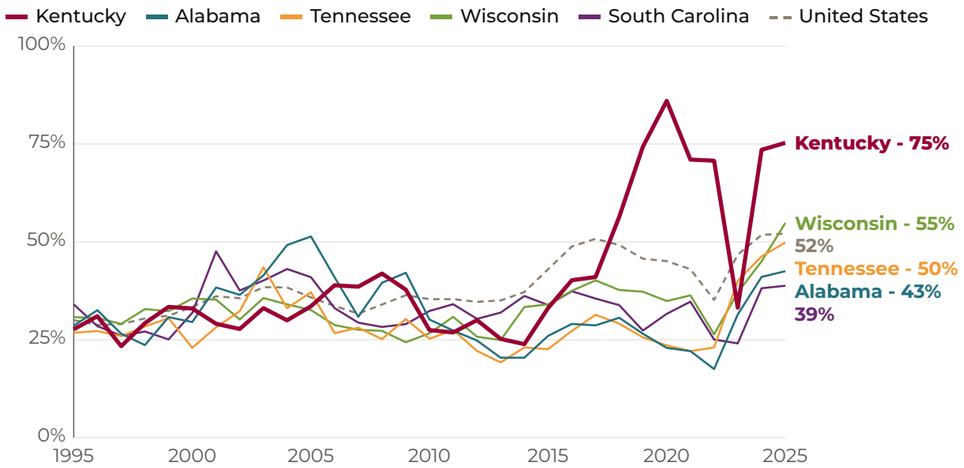
U.S. **17%** · **15th** of 51 · +9.3 pp since 2015

SECTION 11

Competitors

The four states closest in size are Alabama, Tennessee, Wisconsin, South Carolina. Kentucky ranks 1st of the five on the international share of STEM master's; Kentucky is the most dependent at 75%.

Figure 22 How Dependent Are Kentucky and Its Peers on International STEM Master's?



Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

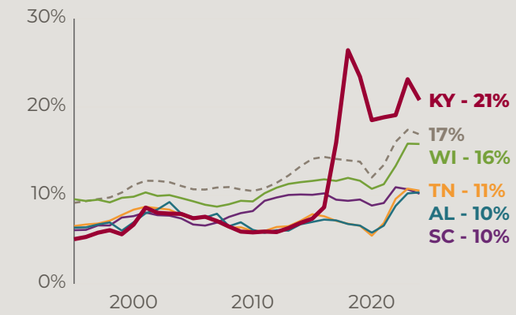
KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

Table 4 How Does Kentucky Compare With States of Similar Size?

Measure	KY	AL	TN	WI	SC	U.S.
Students enrolled	**290K**	311K	325K	328K	256K	19.7M
Graduate share of students	**21%**	18%	17%	13%	12%	17%
STEM share of bachelor's	**17%**	24%	18%	26%	23%	24%
STEM share of master's	**27%**	21%	16%	20%	16%	23%
International STEM master's	**4.04K**	1.47K	1.14K	1.29K	462	117K
Share of U.S. international STEM master's	**3.5%**	1.3%	1.0%	1.1%	0.4%	–
Int. share of STEM master's	**75%**	43%	50%	55%	39%	52%
Int. share of STEM research doctorates	**44%**	49%	35%	37%	41%	43%
Int. share of grad students	**21%**	10%	11%	16%	10%	17%
Int. share of undergraduate enrollment	**1.4%**	1.5%	2.0%	2.6%	1.2%	3.0%
Six-year graduation rate	**58%**	60%	58%	67%	62%	65%
In-state tuition, public 4-year	**$11.9K**	$11.6K	$11K	$9.42K	$12.8K	$9.71K
Appropriations per student	**$7.45K**	$11.4K	$12.1K	$11.4K	$9.11K	$11.4K
Average faculty salary	**$76.7K**	$86.4K	$92.8K	$96.1K	$83.9K	$106K
First-time students from in state	**77%**	68%	76%	73%	72%	–
Net migration per 100 residents	**+7**	+23	+1	+6	+14	–

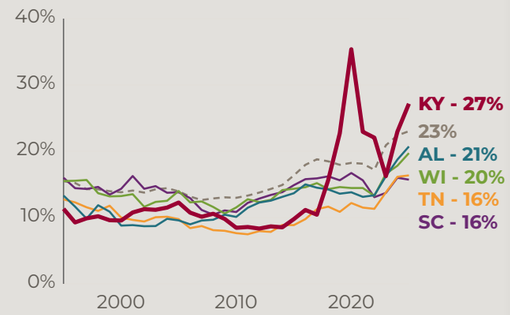
Latest year for each measure. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 23 Int. share of grad students



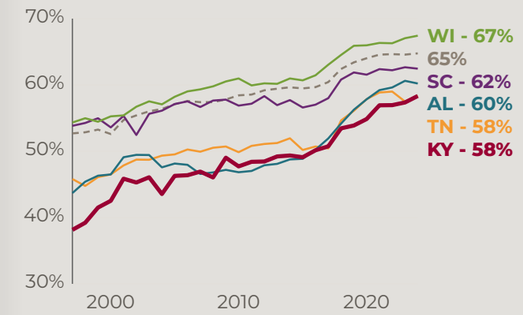
Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 24 STEM share of master's



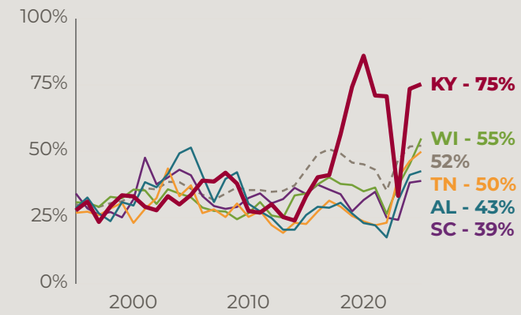
Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 25 Six-year graduation rate



Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 26 Int. share of STEM master's

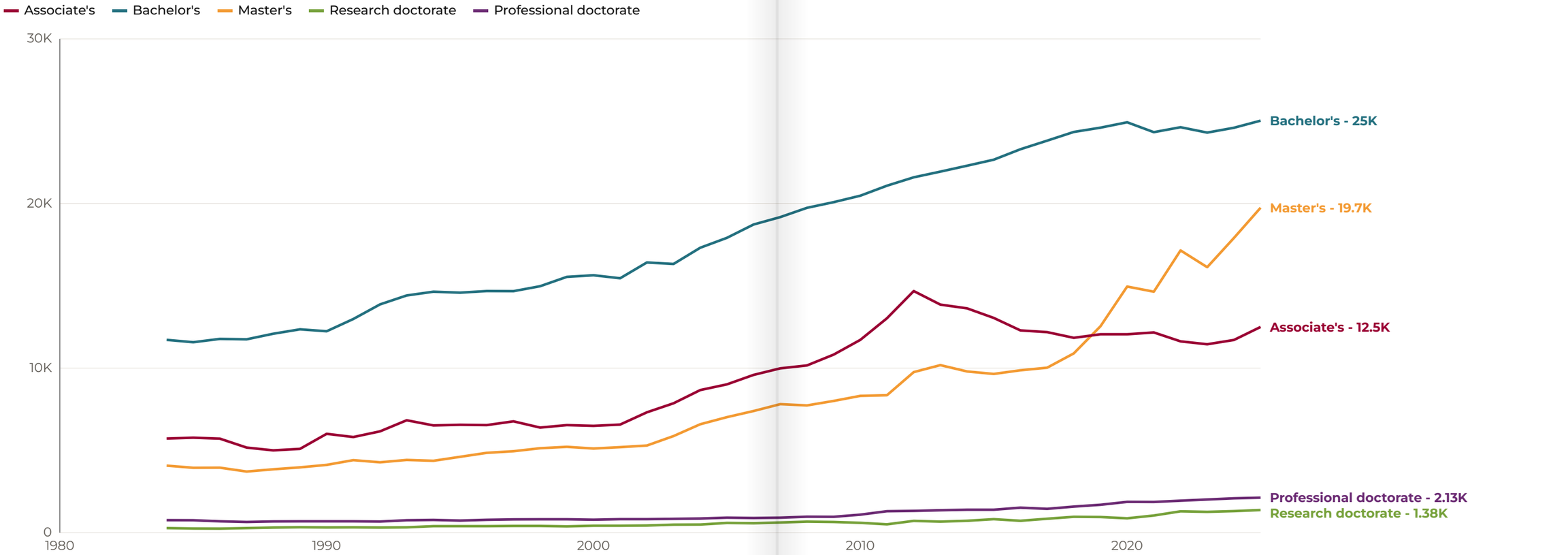


Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 12

Fields of Study

Figure 27 How Many Degrees Does Kentucky Award?

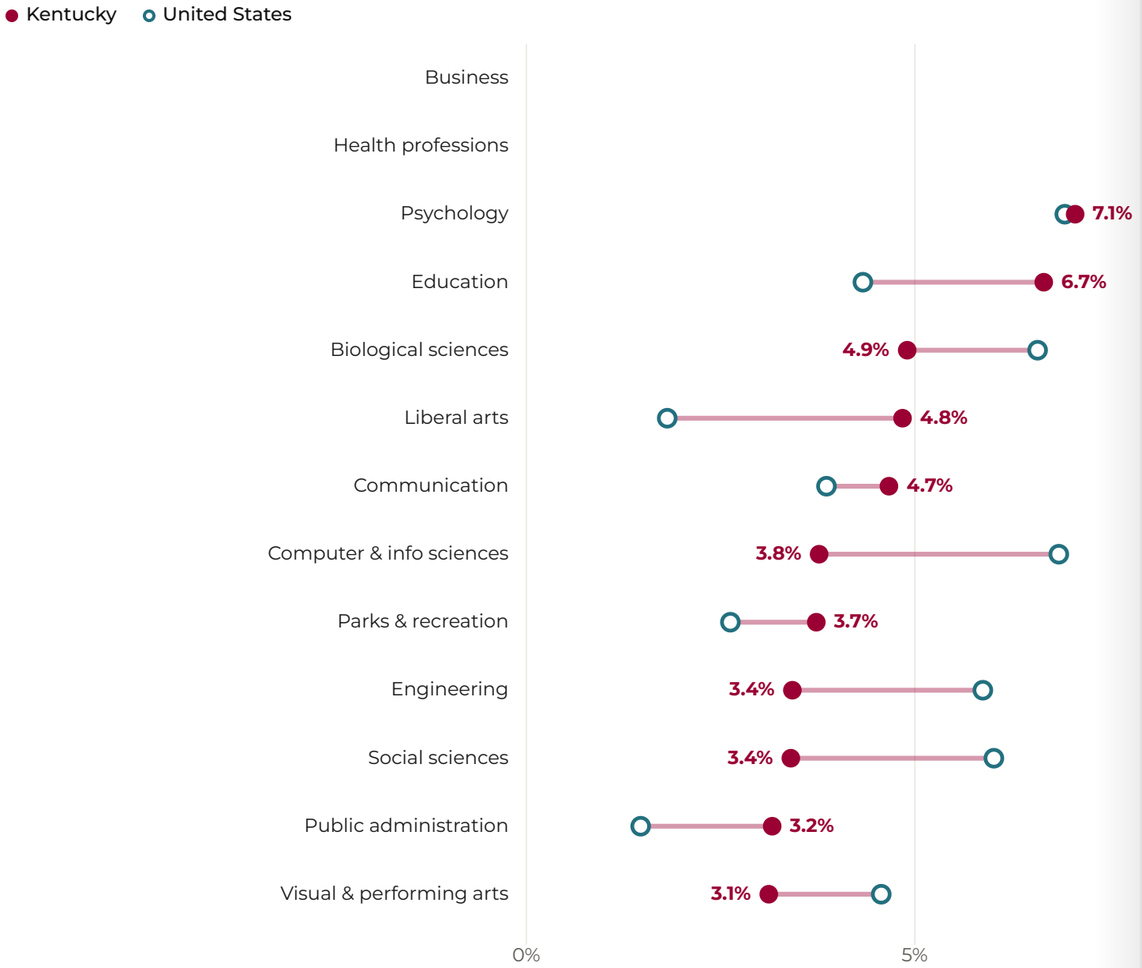


Degrees awarded by level, first majors. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

In 2025, Kentucky's institutions awarded 12.5K associate's degrees, 25K bachelor's degrees, 19.7K master's degrees, 1.38K research doctorate degrees, 2.13K professional doctorate degrees.

Since 2015: associate's down 4%; bachelor's up 10%; master's up 105%; research doctorate up 67%; professional doctorate up 52%. The state awards 11.0 bachelor's degrees for every 100 undergraduates (U.S. 12.3).

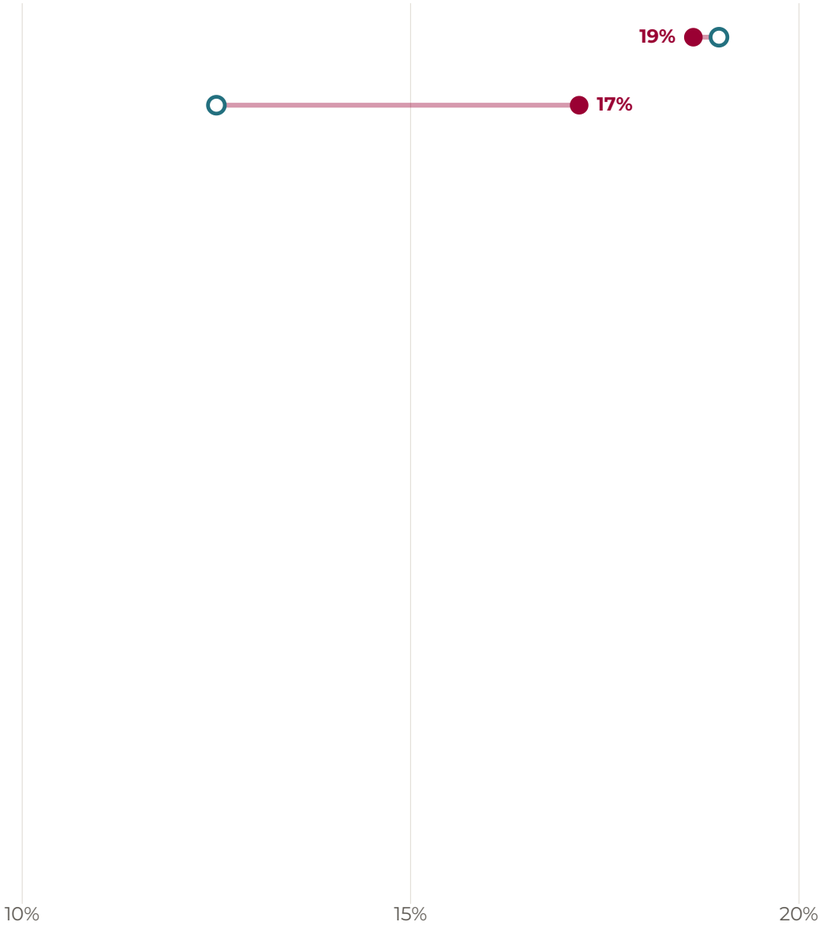
Figure 28 What Do Kentucky's Bachelor's Graduates Study?



Share of bachelor's degrees by field, 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Kentucky's largest bachelor's fields are business (19%; U.S. 19%), health professions (17%; U.S. 13%), psychology (7.1%; U.S. 6.9%).

Relative to the nation, Kentucky's bachelor's degrees are most concentrated in liberal arts (2.67× the U.S. share), agriculture (2.54× the U.S. share), public administration (2.15× the U.S. share).



3.8%

Bachelor's in computer science, 2025

U.S. **6.9%** · **43rd** of 51 · +1.8 pp since 2015

5.0%

Bachelor's in engineering, 2025

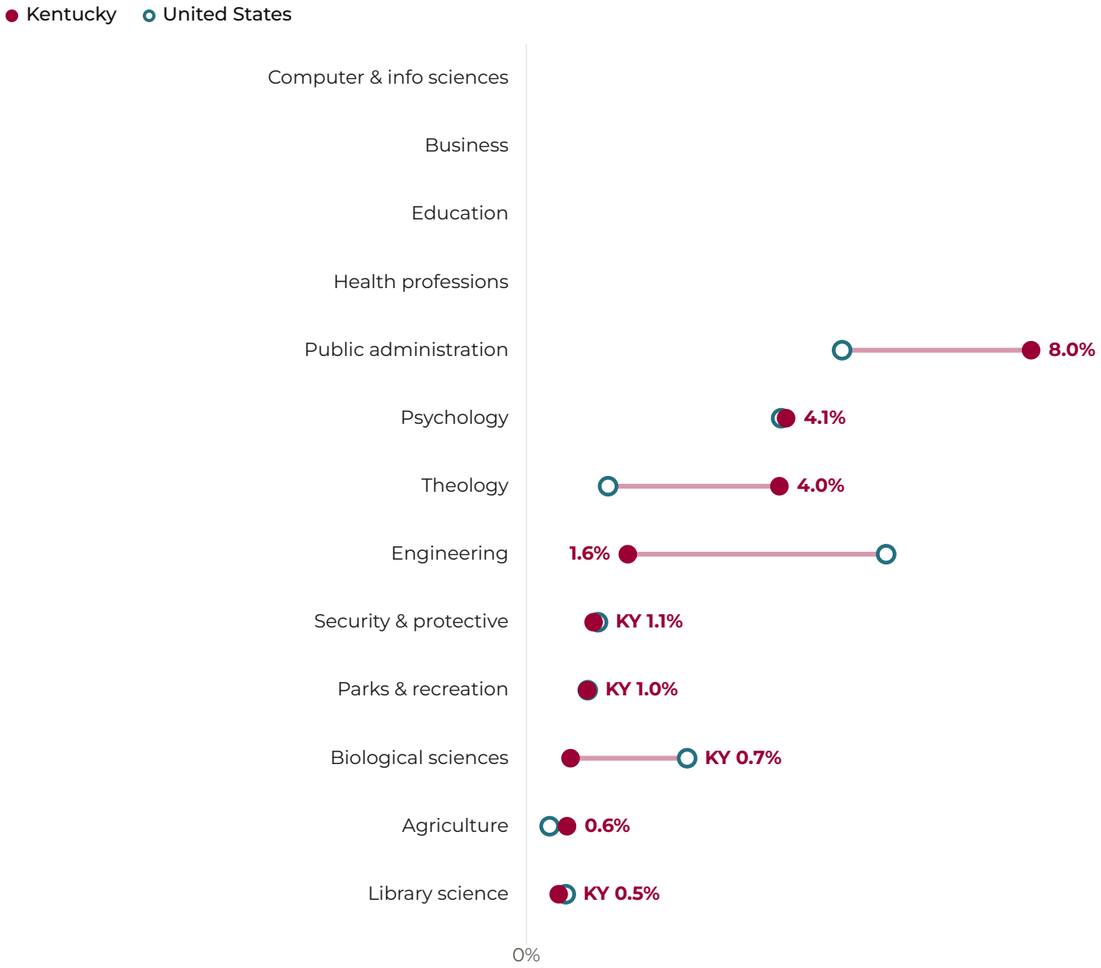
U.S. **6.8%** · **40th** of 51 · −0.6 pp since 2015

19%

Bachelor's in business, 2025

U.S. **19%** · **30th** of 51 · +2.2 pp since 2015

Figure 29 What Do Kentucky's Master's Graduates Study?



Share of master's degrees by field, 2025; largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Kentucky's largest master's fields are computer & info sciences (23%; U.S. 10%), business (18%; U.S. 21%), education (18%; U.S. 15%).

International students earn 29% of all master's degrees in the state (U.S. 22%), and STEM fields account for 27% of them.

27%
STEM share of master's, 2025
U.S. **23%** · **9th** of 51 · +17.4 pp since 2015

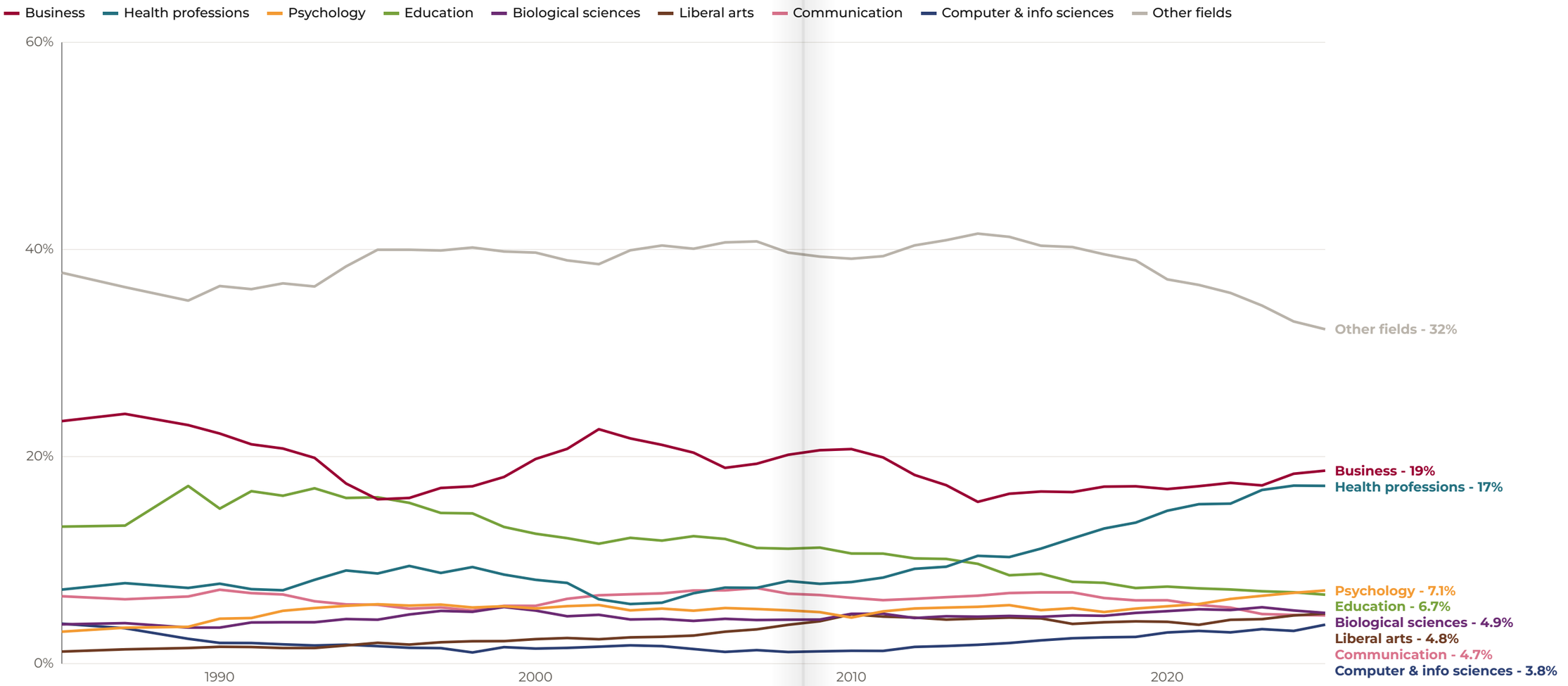
29%
Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **7th** of 51 · +21.6 pp since 2015

84%
Int. share of CS master's, 2025
U.S. **65%** · **8th** of 47 · +25.5 pp since 2015

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

Figure 30 How Has Kentucky's Bachelor's Field Mix Changed?



Share of bachelor's degrees in the largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Since 2015, health professions has gained the most ground, 6.9 points of the state's bachelor's degrees, while communication lost the most (2.2 points).

The chart follows the share of bachelor's degrees in each of the state's largest fields; smaller fields are grouped as other fields.

FIELDS OF STUDY

Where Is Kentucky Specialized, and What Do Its Doctoral Graduates Study?

The location quotient divides a field's share of Kentucky's bachelor's degrees by its share of all U.S. bachelor's degrees in 2025. A quotient of 1.00 means the same share as the nation; 2.00 means twice the national share. The table lists the ten fields with the highest quotients among fields with at least 50 degrees.

Highest location quotients. Liberal arts 2.67 (4.8% of the state's bachelor's degrees; U.S. 1.8%); agriculture 2.54 (2.6% of the state's bachelor's degrees; U.S. 1.0%); public administration 2.15 (3.2% of the state's bachelor's degrees; U.S. 1.5%).

Table 5 Where Is Kentucky Most Specialized?

Field	Location quotient	State share	U.S. share	Degrees
Liberal arts	**2.67**	4.8%	1.8%	1.21K
Agriculture	**2.54**	2.6%	1.0%	652
Public administration	**2.15**	3.2%	1.5%	792
Theology	**1.99**	0.6%	0.3%	142
Engineering technology	**1.73**	1.5%	0.9%	387
Education	**1.54**	6.7%	4.3%	1.67K
Parks & recreation	**1.42**	3.7%	2.6%	934
Health professions	**1.37**	17%	13%	4.3K
Communication	**1.21**	4.7%	3.9%	1.17K
Psychology	**1.02**	7.1%	6.9%	1.77K

Bachelor's degrees; location quotient = state share ÷ U.S. share; fields with 50+ degrees. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

17%
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025
U.S. **24%** · **49th** of 51

3.8%
Bachelor's in computer science, 2025
U.S. **6.9%** · **43rd** of 51

5.0%
Bachelor's in engineering, 2025
U.S. **6.8%** · **40th** of 51

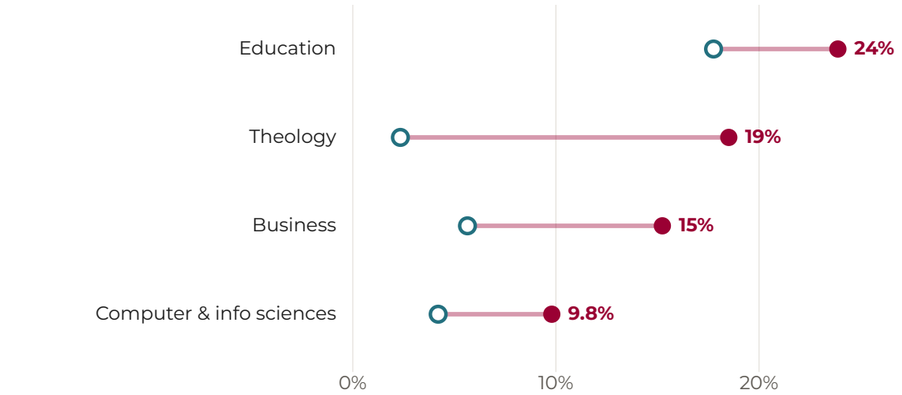
19%
Bachelor's in business, 2025
U.S. **19%** · **30th** of 51

Each row is a field's share of the research doctorates awarded in Kentucky in 2025 (filled dot), against its share nationally (open dot), for the ten largest fields with at least 20 doctorates. Research doctorates exclude professional doctorates such as the M.D. and J.D.

Largest doctoral fields. Education 24% (U.S. 18%); theology 19% (U.S. 2.3%); business 15% (U.S. 5.6%).

STEM share of research doctorates. 23% in 2025 (U.S. 39%; 47th of 51 states), down 1.0 point from 24% in 2024, and down 1.8 points since 2015 (25%).

Figure 31 What Do Kentucky's Doctoral Graduates Study?



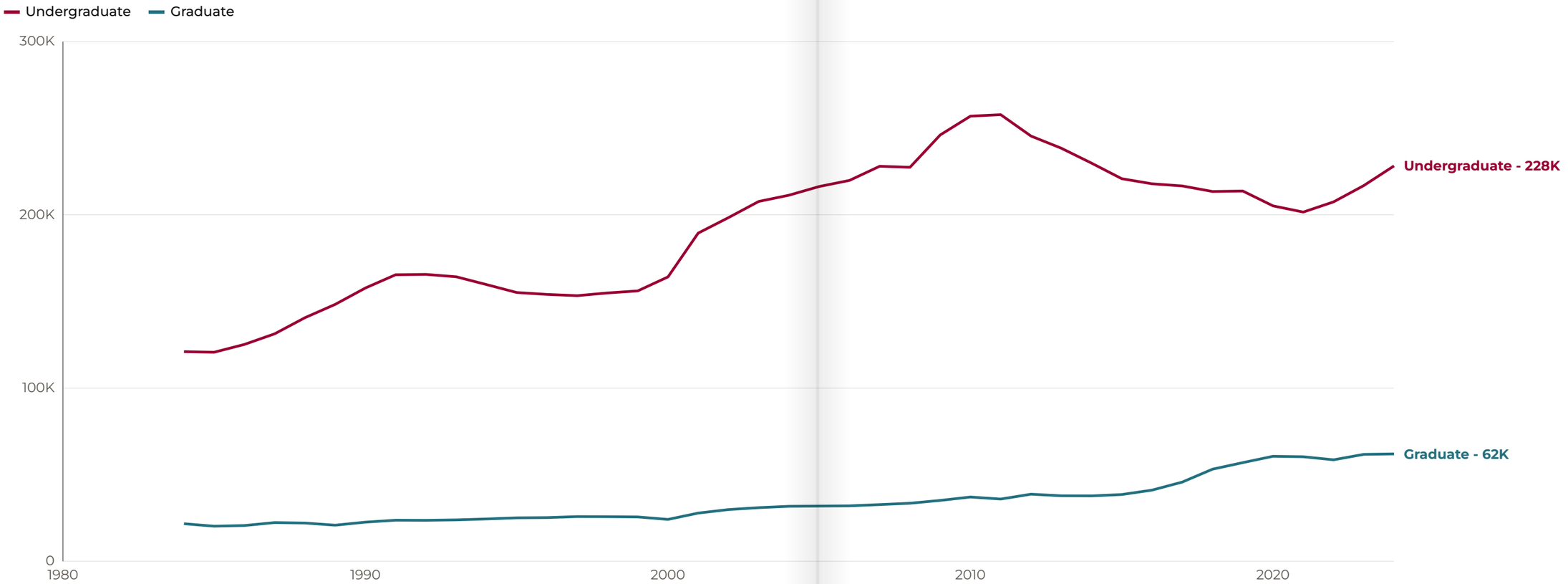
Share of research doctorates by field, 2025; fields with 20+ doctorates. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

SECTION 13

Students and Money

Figure 32 How Has Enrollment Changed?



Fall headcount enrollment. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

In fall 2024, Kentucky enrolled 228K undergraduates and 62K graduate students, 290K in all (25th of 51).

Undergraduate enrollment is up 3% since 2015 and graduate enrollment up 61% since 2015. Graduate students are 21% of all students (U.S. 17%).

290K

Students enrolled, 2024

U.S. **19.7M** · **25th** of 51 · +12% since 2015

21%

Graduate share of students, 2024

U.S. **17%** · **10th** of 51 · +6.5 pp since 2015

43%

Students attending part-time, 2024

U.S. **39%** · **15th** of 51 · +6.1 pp since 2015

STUDENTS AND MONEY

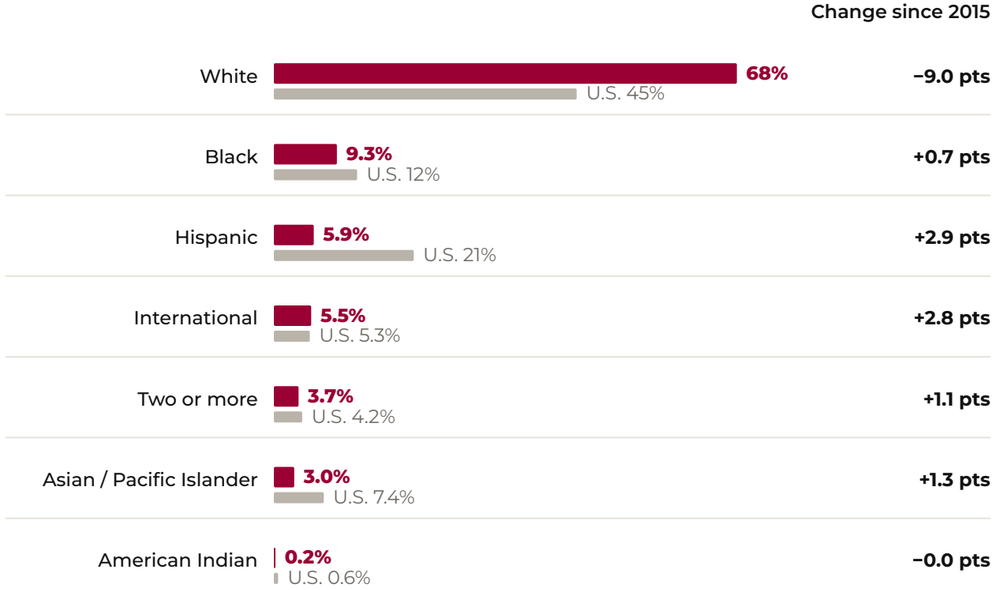
Who Enrolls in Kentucky, and Where?

In fall 2024, White students were the largest group at Kentucky's degree-granting institutions, **68%** of enrollment against 45% nationally, down 9.0 points since 2015.

Black students were **9.3%** (U.S. 12%), up 0.7 points since 2015; Hispanic students were **5.9%** (U.S. 21%), up 2.9 points since 2015.

International students were **5.5%** (U.S. 5.3%), up 2.8 points since 2015, and Students of two or more races were **3.7%** (U.S. 4.2%), up 1.1 points since 2015. "International" counts U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas, whatever their race.

Figure 33 Who Enrolls in Kentucky?



Share of fall 2024 headcount enrollment by race and ethnicity; students of unknown race are left out of the chart. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

68%
White students
U.S. **45%** · −9.0 pp since 2015

9.3%
Black students
U.S. **12%** · +0.7 pp since 2015

43%
At public 4-year institutions
−5.2 pp since 2015

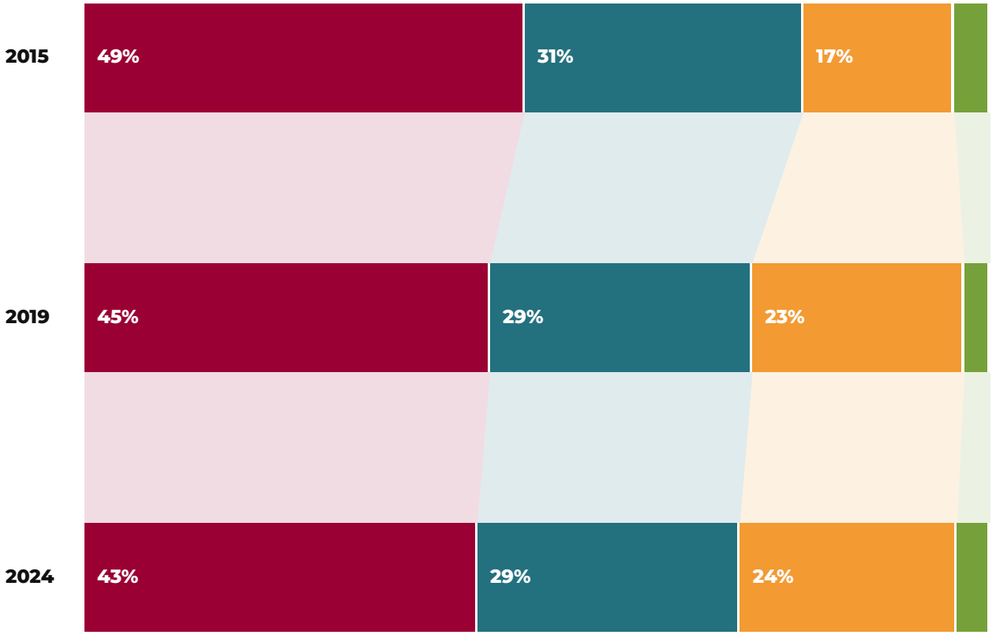
29%
At public 2-year institutions
−1.8 pp since 2015

Public 4-year institutions enrolled **43%** of students, down 5.2 points from 49% in 2015 in fall 2024. Public 2-year institutions enrolled **29%** of students, down 1.8 points from 31% in 2015.

Private nonprofit institutions enrolled **24%** of students, up 7.3 points from 17% in 2015, and for-profit institutions enrolled **3.7%** of students, down 0.3 points from 4.0% in 2015.

Public institutions together enrolled **72%** of students, against 73% nationally, 33rd among the states.

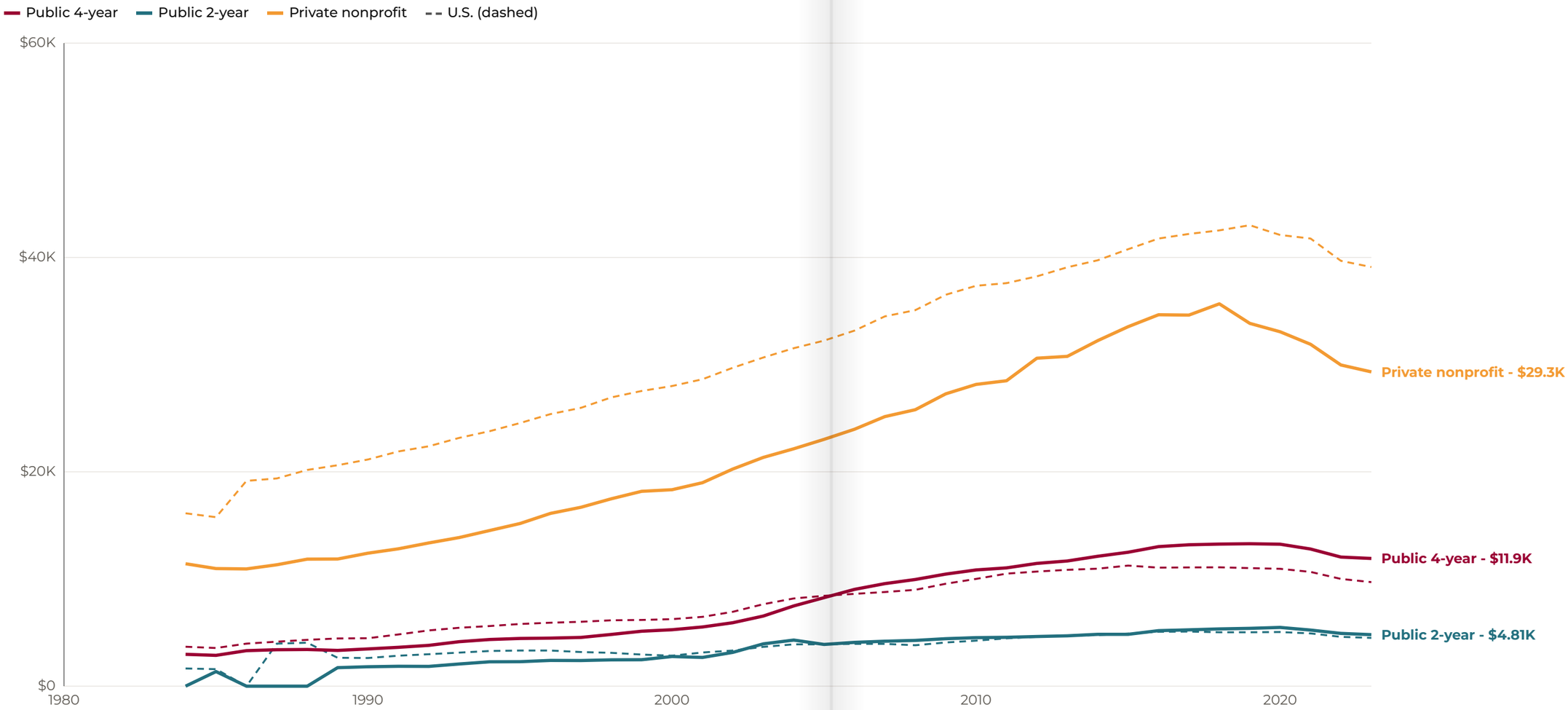
Figure 34 Where Do Students Enroll?



Share of fall headcount enrollment by sector, 2015, 2019, 2024. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

Figure 35 What Does In-State Tuition Cost?



Published in-state tuition and fees, 2024 dollars (CPI-U); state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

In-state tuition and fees at Kentucky's public four-year institutions are $11.9K (2023, 2024 dollars), 23% above the U.S. ($9.71K); the state ranks 14th of 51.

State and local appropriations come to $7.45K per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions (45th of 51), and tuition makes up 52% of their core revenue (U.S. 43%).

$11.9K

In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023

U.S. **$9.71K** · **14th** of 51 · −4.6% since 2015

$7.45K

Appropriations per student, 2024

U.S. **$11.4K** · **45th** of 51 · +2.1% since 2015

52%

Tuition share of public revenue, 2024

U.S. **43%** · **15th** of 51 · −1.3 pp since 2015

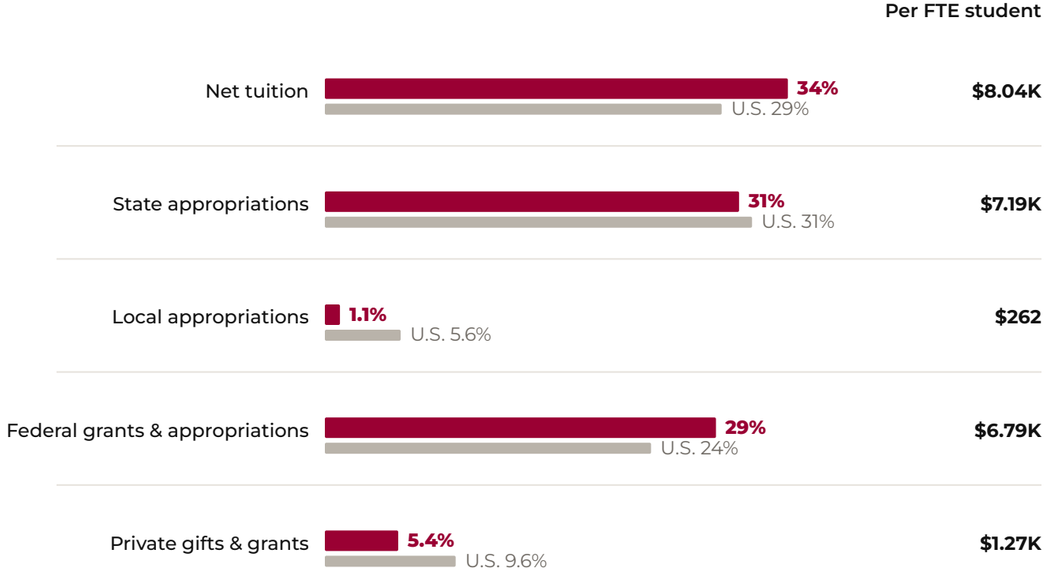
STUDENTS AND MONEY

How Are Kentucky's Public Institutions Funded, and What Do They Produce?

The bars give each source's share of the core revenue of Kentucky's public institutions, with the nation for comparison, and at right the dollars per full-time-equivalent (FTE) student it provides. Values are in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Net tuition is tuition and fees after institutional discounts and allowances.

Net tuition per FTE student. $8.04K in FY2024 (U.S. $8.96K), down 2.3% from $8.22K in FY2023, and down 9.7% since FY2015 ($8.9K).

Figure 36 How Are Public Institutions Funded?



Share of core revenue per FTE student by source, public institutions, FY2024; dollars per FTE at right, 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS Finance.

$11.9K
In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023
U.S. **$9.71K** · **14th** of 51

$7.45K
Appropriations per student, 2024
U.S. **$11.4K** · **45th** of 51

52%
Tuition share of public revenue, 2024
U.S. **43%** · **15th** of 51

58%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · **38th** of 51

The table brings together five measures of what public higher education costs and what it produces in Kentucky: in-state tuition at public four-year institutions, state and local appropriations per full-time-equivalent student, tuition's share of public institutions' core revenue, the six-year bachelor's graduation rate, and the average full-time faculty salary.

In-state tuition, public 4-year. $11.9K in 2023 (U.S. $9.71K; 14th of 51 states), down 1.1% from $12.1K in 2022, and down 4.6% since 2015 ($12.5K).

Table 6 Money and Results

Measure	Year	Kentucky	U.S.	Rank	Change since 2015
In-state tuition, public 4-year	2023	**$11.9K**	$9.71K	14th of 51	−4.6%
Appropriations per student	2024	**$7.45K**	$11.4K	45th of 51	+2.1%
Tuition share of public revenue	2024	**52%**	43%	15th of 51	−1.3 pp
Six-year graduation rate	2024	**58%**	65%	38th of 51	+9.3 pp
Average faculty salary	2024	**$76.7K**	$106K	48th of 51	−12%

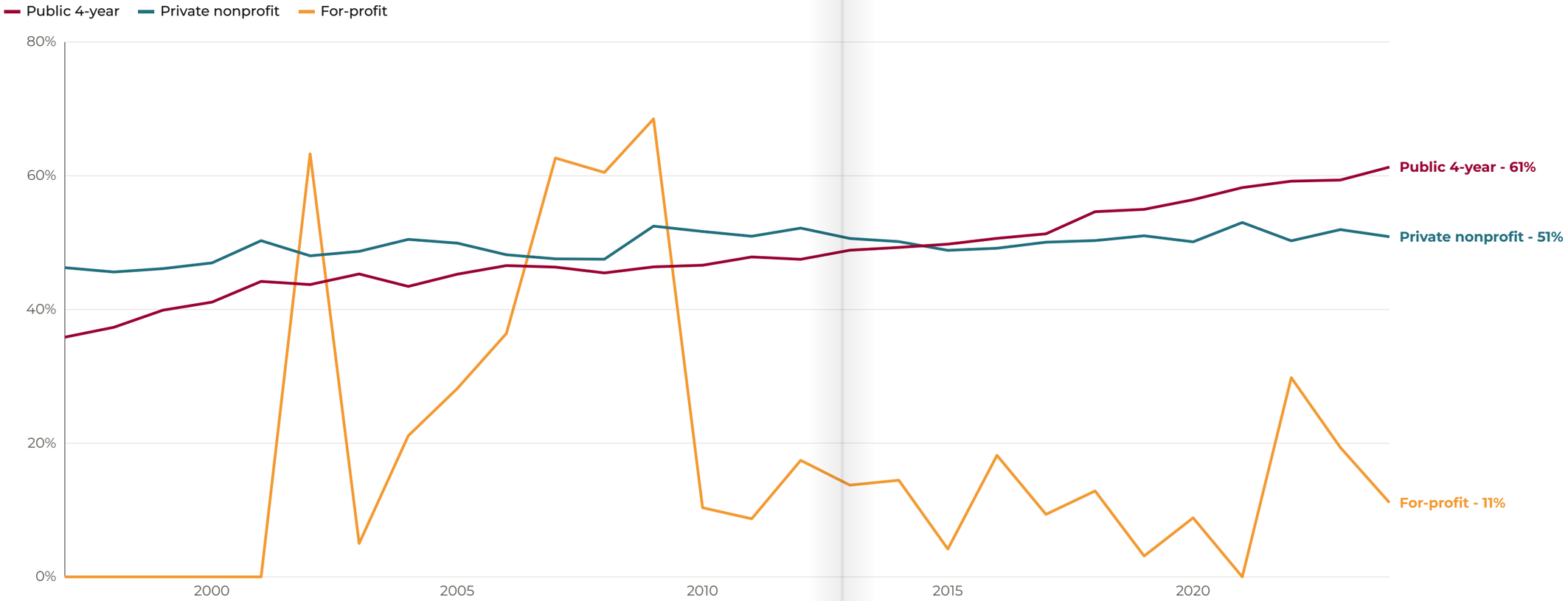
Rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Dollars in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS.

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

SECTION 14

Student Outcomes

Figure 37 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Sector?



Six-year bachelor's graduation rate by sector of institution. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

58% of students who started a bachelor's degree at a four-year institution in Kentucky graduated within six years (2024), 6.4 points below the U.S. (65%); the state ranks 38th of 51.

By sector: public 4-year 61%, private nonprofit 51%, for-profit 11%. At two-year institutions, 48% complete within 150% of normal time (U.S. 41%).

58%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · **38th** of 51 · +9.3 pp since 2015

48%
Two-year completion rate, 2024
U.S. **41%** · **10th** of 50 · +20.9 pp since 2015

11.0
Bachelor's per 100 undergraduates, 2025
U.S. **12.3** · **43rd** of 51 · +1.1 since 2015

STUDENT OUTCOMES

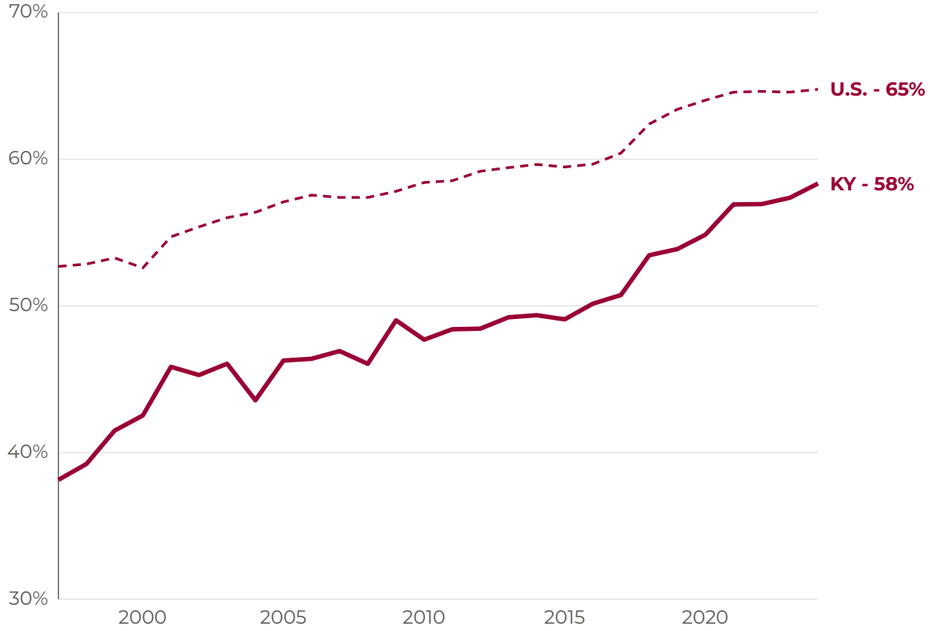
How Many of Kentucky's Students Graduate?

The line follows the share of first-time, full-time bachelor's-degree students at Kentucky's four-year institutions who graduated from the institution where they started within six years (150% of normal time). Each year is the cohort that entered six years earlier. The state is solid and the United States dashed.

Six-year graduation rate. 58% in 2024 (U.S. 65%), up 1.0 point from 57% in 2023, and up 9.3 points since 2015 (49%).

Public 4-year institutions. 61% in 2024, up 1.9 points from 59% in 2023, and up 11.5 points since 2015 (50%).

Figure 38 Six-Year Bachelor's Graduation Rate



Four-year institutions; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

58%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · **38th** of 51

48%
Two-year completion rate, 2024
U.S. **41%** · **10th** of 50

11.0
Bachelor's per 100 undergraduates, 2025
U.S. **12.3** · **43rd** of 51

Each row is the six-year bachelor's graduation rate for one racial or ethnic group of students at Kentucky's four-year institutions (filled dot), against the national rate for the same group (open dot). Groups with fewer than 100 students in the cohort are left out.

White. 61% in 2024 (U.S. 68%).

Hispanic. 55% in 2024 (U.S. 59%).

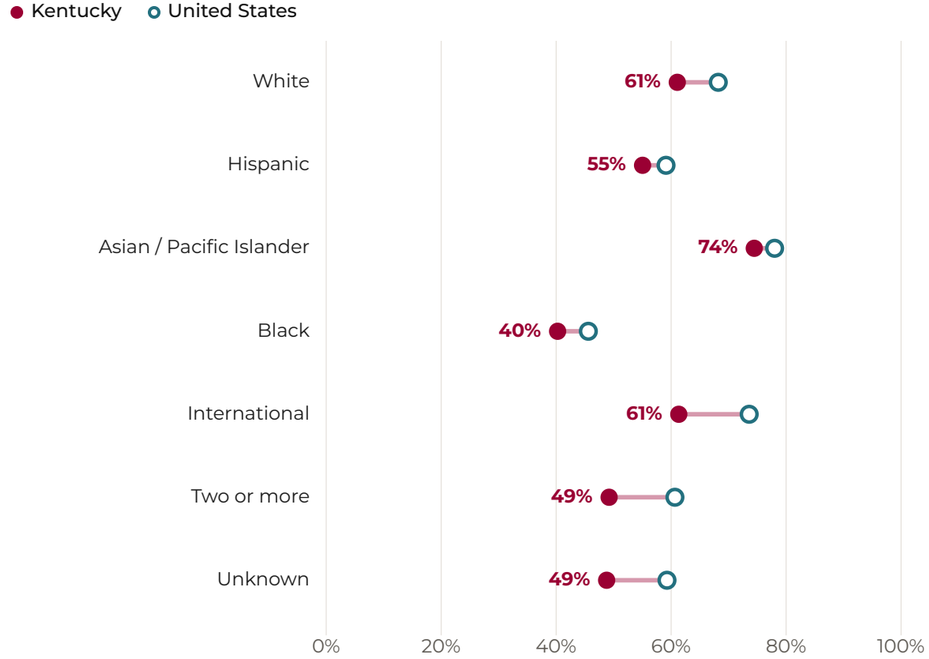
Asian / Pacific Islander. 74% in 2024 (U.S. 78%).

Black. 40% in 2024 (U.S. 46%).

International. 61% in 2024 (U.S. 74%).

Two or more. 49% in 2024 (U.S. 61%).

Figure 39 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Race and Ethnicity?



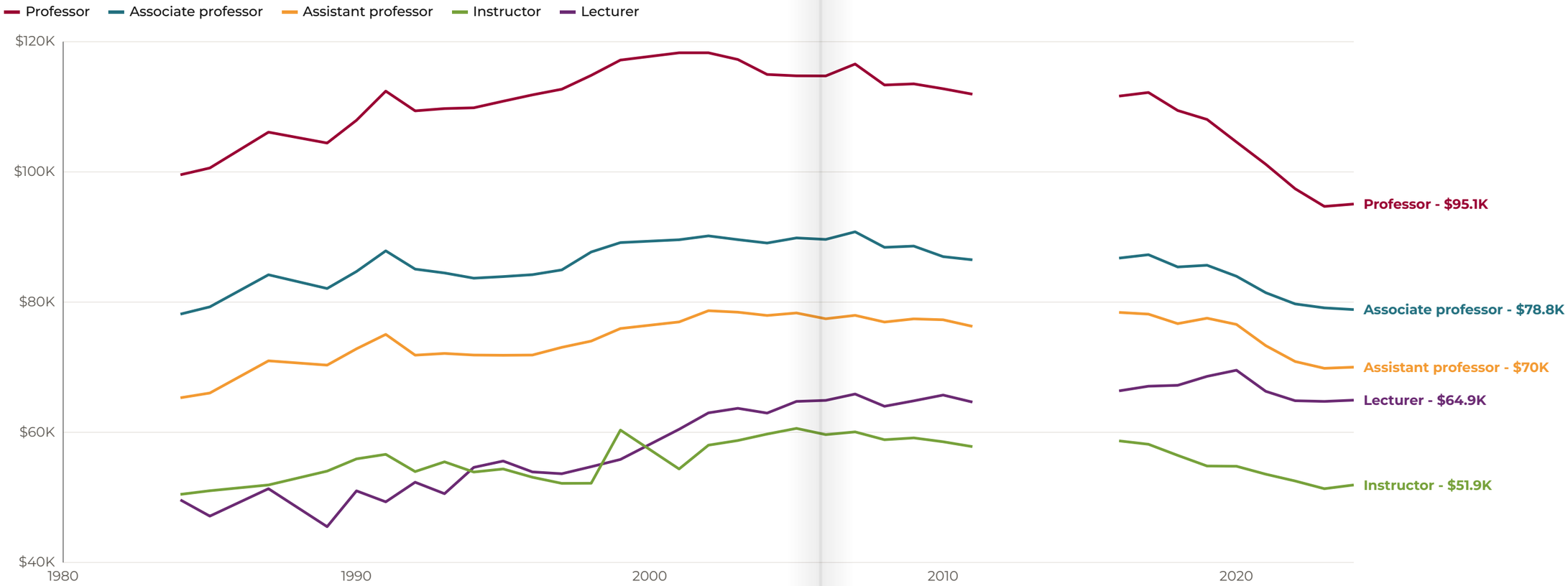
Six-year rate, 2024; groups with 100+ students. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

SECTION 15

Faculty

Figure 40 What Do Kentucky's Faculty Earn, by Rank?



Average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts, by academic rank, 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS Human Resources.

Full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts at Kentucky's institutions earned an average of $76.7K in 2024 (2024 dollars), 27% below the U.S. ($106K); the state ranks 48th of 51. By rank (2024): professors $95.1K, associate professors $78.8K, assistant professors $70K, instructors $51.9K, lecturers $64.9K.

Kentucky's institutions had 9.4K full-time instructional staff in 2024, down 10% since 2015. Average salary across all ranks is down 12% since 2016.

$76.7K

Average faculty salary, 2024

U.S. **$106K** · **48th** of 51 · −12% since 2016

FACULTY

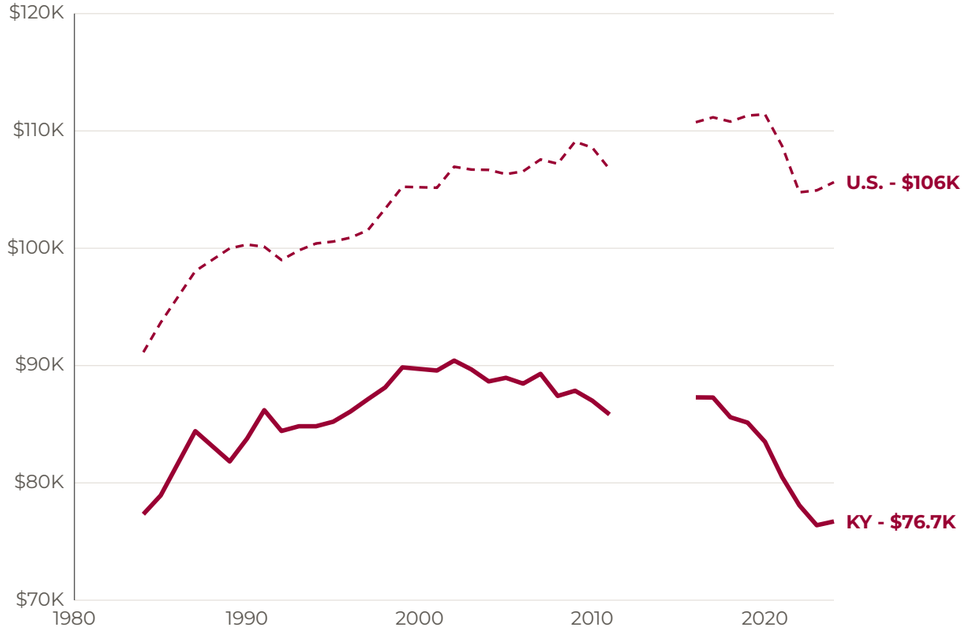
What Do Kentucky's Faculty Earn, and How Many Hold Tenure?

The line follows the average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9- or 10-month contracts at Kentucky's degree-granting institutions, all ranks combined, in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). The state is solid and the United States dashed.

Average salary. $76.7K in 2024 (U.S. $106K), up 0.4% from $76.4K in 2023, and down 12% since 2016 ($87.3K).

State rank on average salary. $76.7K in 2024 (U.S. $106K; 48th of 51 states), up 0.4% from $76.4K in 2023, and down 12% since 2016 ($87.3K).

Figure 41 Average Faculty Salary



Full-time instructional faculty, 9/10-month, 2024 dollars. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

$76.7K
Average faculty salary, 2024
U.S. **$106K** · **48th** of 51

9.4K
Full-time instructional staff, 2024

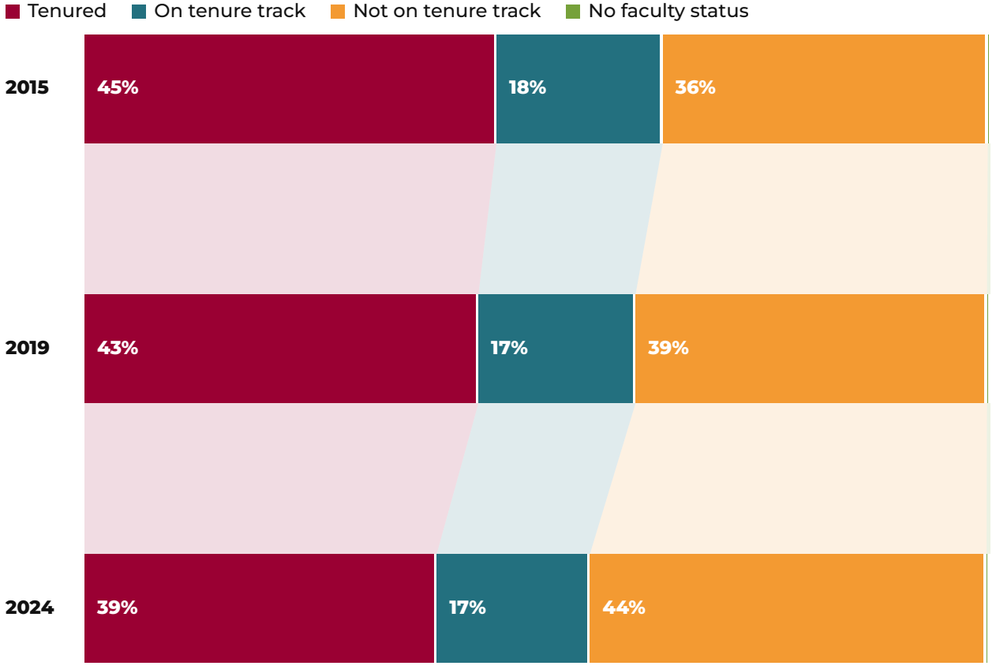
39%
Tenured, 2024

The bars divide Kentucky's full-time instructional staff by tenure status in 2015, 2019 and 2024: tenured, on the tenure track, not on the tenure track (for example, lecturers on fixed-term contracts), and staff at institutions with no tenure system.

Tenured, share of full-time instructional staff. 39% in 2024, down 1.1 points from 40% in 2023, and down 6.6 points since 2015 (45%).

On tenure track, share of full-time instructional staff. 17% in 2024, up 0.3 points from 17% in 2023, and down 1.4 points since 2015 (18%).

Figure 42 Tenure Status

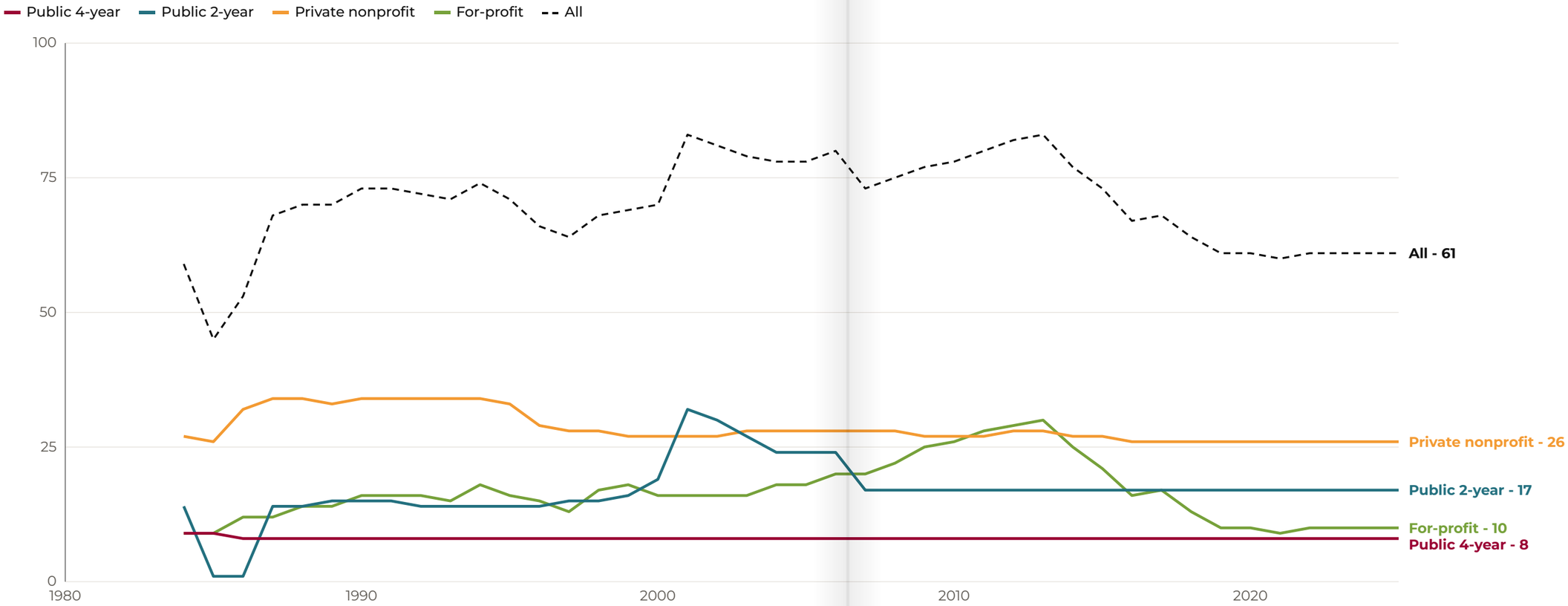


Full-time instructional staff by tenure status, 2015, 2019, 2024. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 16

Institutions

Figure 43 How Many Institutions Does Kentucky Have?



Degree-granting institutions by sector. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Kentucky has 61 degree-granting institutions:8 public 4-year, 17 public 2-year, 26 private nonprofit, 10 for-profit (2025).

The number of institutions is down 16% since 2015. 72% of students attend public institutions and 3.7% attend for-profit ones.

72%

Students at public institutions, 2024

U.S. **73%** · **33rd** of 51 · −7.0 pp since 2015

3.7%

Students at for-profit institutions, 2024

U.S. **5.5%** · **18th** of 51 · −0.3 pp since 2015

30%

Students fully online, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **13th** of 51 · +14.5 pp since 2015

INSTITUTIONS

Which Institutions Lead in Kentucky?

Institutions in Kentucky ranked by the STEM master's and research doctorates they awarded to international students in 2025. The share columns give international students' share of each institution's STEM degrees at that level.

Largest. Campbellsville University (1.69K international STEM master's, – doctorates); Lindsey Wilson University (1.08K international STEM master's, – doctorates); University of the Cumberlands (962 international STEM master's, 68 doctorates).

Table 7 Which Institutions Train the Most International STEM Graduates?

Institution	Intl STEM master's	Int. share	Intl STEM doctorates	Int. share
Campbellsville University Campbellsville · Private nonprofit	**1.69K**	99%	–	–
Lindsey Wilson University Columbia · Private nonprofit	**1.08K**	98%	–	–
University of the Cumberlands Williamsburg · Private nonprofit	**962**	61%	68	53%
University of Kentucky Lexington · Public 4-year	**49**	21%	50	41%
University of Louisville Louisville · Public 4-year	**66**	19%	22	33%
Union Commonwealth University Barbourville · Private nonprofit	**58**	98%	–	–
Murray State University Murray · Public 4-year	**49**	61%	–	–
Northern Kentucky University Highland Heights · Public 4-year	**46**	34%	–	–

Degrees awarded in 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

61
Degree-granting institutions, 2025

72%
Students at public institutions, 2024
U.S. **73%** · **33rd** of 51

3.7%
Students at for-profit institutions, 2024
U.S. **5.5%** · **18th** of 51

30%
Students fully online, 2024
U.S. **27%** · **13th** of 51

Kentucky's largest degree-granting institutions by fall 2024 headcount enrollment, with the international share of graduate students, STEM bachelor's degrees awarded in 2025, the six-year graduation rate and the admission rate (a dash where the institution admits all applicants or does not report one).

Largest. University of Kentucky (34.7K students); University of Louisville (23.1K students); University of the Cumberlands (22.1K students).

Degree-granting institutions. 61 in 2025; 60 of them reported the enrollment and degree data in these tables.

Table 8 What Are Kentucky's Largest Institutions?

Institution	Enrollment	Int. share, grad	STEM bachelor's	Six-year grad rate	Admit rate
University of Kentucky	**34.7K**	9.5%	1.13K	71%	93%
University of Louisville	**23.1K**	9.6%	643	61%	79%
University of the Cumberlands	**22.1K**	31%	103	50%	99%
Western Kentucky University	**16.3K**	3.0%	427	58%	94%
Eastern Kentucky University	**15.7K**	2.8%	283	55%	78%
Northern Kentucky University	**15.3K**	2.5%	400	54%	68%
Jefferson Community and Technical College	**13.4K**	–	–	–	–
Bluegrass Community and Technical College	**13K**	–	–	–	–
Campbellsville University	**10.8K**	69%	29	42%	80%
Murray State University	**10K**	26%	363	64%	86%

Fall 2024 enrollment; degrees 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

NOTES

About These Data

International students

U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas, as IPEDS defines them. IPEDS does not record country of citizenship. Permanent residents count with U.S. citizens.

STEM

CIP families 03, 04, 11, 14, 15, 26, 27 and 40. Doctorates are research and scholarship doctorates; professional doctorates appear only in the degree-count figure. Degrees are first majors only.

Universe

Degree-granting institutions located in the state; Title IV participants from 1996. Geography is the institution's location, not the student's home. Enrollment is fall headcount.

Migration

First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by home state, reported in even years before 2001 and every year since; odd years with incomplete reporting are omitted. Net migration is students arriving from other states minus residents leaving, per 100 resident first-time students.

Money

All dollar values are in 2024 dollars using the CPI-U. Appropriations and revenue are per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions.

Race and ethnicity

IPEDS did not collect race and ethnicity in every year before 2010, and categories changed in 2008–2010; “Two or more” exists only from then.

Countries of citizenship

From DHS SEVIS by the Numbers: active F-1 and M-1 student records in the month named, at every level from primary school to doctorate, by the state of the school. IPEDS records only whether a student is a U.S. nonresident, not where they come from. SEVIS counts are monthly snapshots and are not directly comparable with IPEDS fall enrollment or degree counts.

Peers

Comparison states are the four closest in total fall enrollment.

Source

National Center for Education Statistics, Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS): Institutional Characteristics, Fall Enrollment, Completions, Graduation Rates, Finance, Human Resources and Admissions components, 1980–2025, harmonized into a state panel. Department of Homeland Security, SEVIS by the Numbers data mapping tool, 2014–2026. Generated November 2026.

KENTUCKY · STATE TALENT PROFILE

This page intentionally left blank.

Kentucky – By the Numbers

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION							
Grade 8 mathematics, average score	278	**271**[2024]	−7.1 ▼	272	−9.0 ▼	#28	[5]
Grade 8 mathematics: at or above Proficient	28%	**24%**[2024]	−3.3 pp ▼	27%	−5.3 pp ▼	#32	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics, average score	242	**238**[2024]	−3.9 ▼	237	−2.5 ▼	#25	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics: at or above Proficient	40%	**38%**[2024]	−2.0 pp ▼	39%	0.0 pp	#28	[5]
Grade 8 reading, average score	268	**258**[2024]	−9.8 ▼	257	−7.3 ▼	#22	[5]
Grade 8 reading: at or above Proficient	36%	**29%**[2024]	−7.5 pp ▼	29%	−4.0 pp ▼	#26	[5]
Grade 4 reading, average score	228	**218**[2024]	−10.0 ▼	214	−7.1 ▼	#11	[5]
Grade 8 science, average score, 2009 framework	–	**157**[2015]	–	153	–	#17	[5]
Current spending per public-school pupil	$12.5K	**$14.1K**[2021]	+13% ▲	$16.8K	+12% ▲	#35	[3]
Public high school 4-year graduation rate, ACGR	88%	**90%**[2022]	+2.0 pp ▲	87%	+4.0 pp ▲	#2	[3]
Public high school graduates	43.3K	**46.8K**[2024]	+8.3% ▲	3.49M	+8.8% ▲	#26	[3]
Average public-school teacher salary	$66.9K	**$59.9K**[2022]	−10% ▼	$72.9K	−3.0% ▼	#37	[3]
Pupils per teacher, public schools	16.4	**15.3**[2022]	−1.1 ▼	15.4	−0.6 ▼	#19	[3]
Public elementary and secondary enrollment	687K	**657K**[2024]	−4.3% ▼	49.4M	−2.1% ▼	#28	[3]
Public-school students eligible for free or reduced-price lunch	57%	**57%**[2023]	+0.5 pp ▲	53%	+1.5 pp ▲	#13	[3]
English learners as a share of public-school students	3.0%	**5.4%**[2022]	+2.4 pp ▲	11%	+1.0 pp ▲	#37	[3]
Charter-school share of public-school enrollment	0.0%	**0.0%**[2023]	0.0 pp	7.6%	+2.2 pp ▲	#45	[3]
High schools offering calculus	53%[2016]	**23%**[2024]	−30.3 pp ▼	51%	−5.8 pp ▼	#49	[14]
High schools offering physics	67%[2016]	**87%**[2024]	+19.2 pp ▲	64%	−2.4 pp ▼	#5	[14]
High schools offering chemistry	82%[2016]	**93%**[2024]	+11.2 pp ▲	81%	+0.7 pp ▲	#6	[14]
High schools offering Algebra II	88%[2016]	**94%**[2024]	+6.5 pp ▲	87%	+1.3 pp ▲	#13	[14]
High schools offering computer science	61%[2021]	**72%**[2024]	+11.3 pp ▲	55%	+2.0 pp ▲	#11	[14]
High schools offering any AP course	59%[2016]	**52%**[2024]	−7.1 pp ▼	56%	0.0 pp	#32	[14]
High schools offering AP computer science	29%[2021]	**23%**[2024]	−5.9 pp ▼	25%	+2.6 pp ▲	#27	[14]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

KENTUCKY – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION (CONTINUED)							
High schools offering dual enrollment	56%[2016]	**72%[2024]**	+15.7 pp ▲	71%	+11.1 pp ▲	#34	[14]
AP course enrollments per 100 high-school students	21.3[2016]	**16.3[2024]**	−5.0 ▼	18.4	+1.0 ▲	#20	[14]
Calculus enrollments per 100 high-school students	2.9[2016]	**0.9[2024]**	−2.0 ▼	3.3	−1.0 ▼	#49	[14]
Physics enrollments per 100 high-school students	21.4[2016]	**21.1[2024]**	−0.3 ▼	9.4	−0.4 ▼	#1	[14]
SAT or ACT takers per 100 high-school students	36.1[2016]	**38.4[2024]**	+2.3 ▲	18.1	−2.5 ▼	#1	[14]
Students in gifted and talented programs per 100 students	14.0[2016]	**12.8[2024]**	−1.2 ▼	7.0	+0.4 ▲	#6	[14]
ENROLLMENT AND INSTITUTIONS							
Pell Grant share of undergraduates	41%	**37%[2025]**	−3.5 pp ▼	36%	−0.8 pp ▼	#15	[15]
Fall enrollment	259K	**290K[2024]**	+12% ▲	19.7M	−1.7% ▼	#25	[4]
Share of enrollment at public institutions	79%	**72%[2024]**	−7.0 pp ▼	73%	0.0 pp	#33	[4]
Share of enrollment at for-profit institutions	4.0%	**3.7%[2024]**	−0.3 pp ▼	5.5%	−1.2 pp ▼	#18	[4]
Share of students enrolled part-time	37%	**43%[2024]**	+6.1 pp ▲	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#15	[4]
Share of students who are graduate students	15%	**21%[2024]**	+6.5 pp ▲	17%	+2.0 pp ▲	#10	[4]
Share of students enrolled exclusively online	16%	**30%[2024]**	+14.5 pp ▲	27%	+12.1 pp ▲	#13	[4]
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY							
Research doctorates awarded	503	**455[2025]**	−9.5% ▼	59K	+7.3% ▲	#34	[7]
Science & engineering research doctorates, excluding health	294	**284[2025]**	−3.4% ▼	44.4K	+14% ▲	#34	[7]
Share of U.S. research doctorates	0.9%	**0.8%[2025]**	−0.1 pp ▼	–	–	#34	[7]
Engineering research doctorates	79	**61[2025]**	−23% ▼	10.9K	+9.9% ▲	#34	[7]
Mathematics & computer science research doctorates	33	**18[2025]**	−45% ▼	5.07K	+33% ▲	#40	[7]
STEM master's degrees per research doctorate	4.6	**16.9[2025]**	+12.3 ▲	6.4	+2.1 ▲	#2	[4]
STEM share of bachelor's	16%	**17%[2025]**	+0.9 pp ▲	24%	+5.3 pp ▲	#49	[4]
Share of bachelor's in computer & information sciences	2.0%	**3.8%[2025]**	+1.8 pp ▲	6.9%	+3.7 pp ▲	#43	[4]
Share of bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology	5.6%	**5.0%[2025]**	−0.6 pp ▼	6.8%	+0.7 pp ▲	#40	[4]
Share of bachelor's in mathematics & statistics	1.0%	**0.6%[2025]**	−0.4 pp ▼	1.2%	0.0 pp	#43	[4]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). “pp” is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

KENTUCKY – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY (CONTINUED)							
Share of bachelor's in biological & biomedical sciences	4.6%	**4.9%**[2025]	+0.3 pp ▲	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#48	[4]
Share of bachelor's in physical sciences	1.6%	**1.3%**[2025]	−0.4 pp ▼	1.3%	−0.3 pp ▼	#28	[4]
Share of bachelor's in health professions	10%	**17%**[2025]	+6.9 pp ▲	12%	+1.1 pp ▲	#6	[4]
Share of bachelor's in business	16%	**19%**[2025]	+2.2 pp ▲	19%	−0.1 pp ▼	#30	[4]
STEM share of master's	9.8%	**27%**[2025]	+17.4 pp ▲	23%	+6.7 pp ▲	#9	[4]
Share of master's in computer & information sciences	2.5%	**23%**[2025]	+20.8 pp ▲	10%	+6.3 pp ▲	#3	[4]
Share of master's in engineering & eng. technology	4.0%	**2.1%**[2025]	−1.9 pp ▼	6.7%	−0.2 pp ▼	#49	[4]
Share of master's in mathematics & statistics	0.7%	**0.5%**[2025]	−0.2 pp ▼	1.3%	+0.3 pp ▲	#41	[4]
Share of master's in biological & biomedical sciences	1.4%	**0.7%**[2025]	−0.7 pp ▼	2.5%	+0.6 pp ▲	#50	[4]
Share of master's in physical sciences	0.6%	**0.3%**[2025]	−0.4 pp ▼	0.8%	−0.1 pp ▼	#50	[4]
Share of master's in health professions	16%	**14%**[2025]	−1.6 pp ▼	15%	+1.7 pp ▲	#28	[4]
Share of master's in business	14%	**18%**[2025]	+4.6 pp ▲	21%	−3.2 pp ▼	#36	[4]
STEM share of research doctorates	25%	**23%**[2025]	−1.8 pp ▼	39%	−2.2 pp ▼	#47	[4]
Share of research doctorates in computer & information sciences	1.2%	**9.8%**[2025]	+8.6 pp ▲	4.2%	+1.4 pp ▲	#3	[4]
Share of research doctorates in engineering & eng. technology	10%	**4.6%**[2025]	−5.4 pp ▼	14%	−1.0 pp ▼	#50	[4]
Share of research doctorates in mathematics & statistics	2.3%	**0.9%**[2025]	−1.4 pp ▼	2.4%	−0.2 pp ▼	#42	[4]
Share of research doctorates in biological & biomedical sciences	8.1%	**5.4%**[2025]	−2.8 pp ▼	10%	−1.1 pp ▼	#46	[4]
Share of research doctorates in physical sciences	3.2%	**2.2%**[2025]	−0.9 pp ▼	7.1%	−1.1 pp ▼	#49	[4]
Share of research doctorates in health professions	4.0%	**2.0%**[2025]	−2.0 pp ▼	12%	+3.5 pp ▲	#48	[4]
Share of research doctorates in business	3.4%	**15%**[2025]	+11.8 pp ▲	5.6%	+1.3 pp ▲	#3	[4]
Bachelor's degrees per 100 undergraduates	9.9	**11.0**[2025]	+1.1 ▲	12.3	+1.4 ▲	#43	[4]
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS							
First-time students from outside the U.S.	1.4%[2016]	**1.6%**[2024]	+0.2 pp ▲	3.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#40	[4]
STEM master's degrees earned by international students	311	**4.04K**[2025]	12.98× ▲	117K	2.18× ▲	#9	[4]
Share of all U.S. international STEM master's degrees	0.6%	**3.5%**[2025]	+2.9 pp ▲	–	–	#9	[4]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

KENTUCKY – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
International share of undergraduate enrollment	1.9%	**1.4%**[2024]	−0.6 pp ▼	3.0%	−0.3 pp ▼	#45	[4]
International share of graduate enrollment	7.4%	**21%**[2024]	+13.4 pp ▲	17%	+2.8 pp ▲	#9	[4]
International share of all bachelor's	2.7%	**3.0%**[2025]	+0.3 pp ▲	4.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#30	[4]
International share of STEM bachelor's	6.0%	**4.6%**[2025]	−1.5 pp ▼	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#32	[4]
International share of all master's	7.2%	**29%**[2025]	+21.6 pp ▲	22%	+6.2 pp ▲	#7	[4]
International share of STEM master's	33%	**75%**[2025]	+42.2 pp ▲	52%	+9.1 pp ▲	#2	[4]
International share of computer & information sciences master's	58%	**84%**[2025]	+25.5 pp ▲	65%	+10.1 pp ▲	#8	[4]
International share of engineering & eng. technology master's	26%	**22%**[2025]	−3.5 pp ▼	50%	+0.9 pp ▲	#44	[4]
International share of mathematics & statistics master's	31%	**38%**[2025]	+6.4 pp ▲	55%	+6.1 pp ▲	#22	[4]
International share of biological & biomedical sciences master's	15%	**12%**[2025]	−3.7 pp ▼	23%	+6.2 pp ▲	#39	[4]
International share of physical sciences master's	40%	**40%**[2025]	+0.1 pp ▲	33%	+3.6 pp ▲	#9	[4]
International share of all research doctorates	19%	**20%**[2025]	+0.4 pp ▲	25%	−1.0 pp ▼	#37	[4]
International share of STEM research doctorates	51%	**44%**[2025]	−7.2 pp ▼	43%	−0.5 pp ▼	#19	[4]
International share of computer & information sciences research doctorates	32%[2022]	**52%**[2025]	+20.0 pp ▲	56%	−3.5 pp ▼	#18	[4]
International share of engineering & eng. technology research doctorates	66%	**56%**[2025]	−10.0 pp ▼	55%	−1.0 pp ▼	#20	[4]
International share of mathematics & statistics research doctorates	–	**31%**[2024]	–	52%	–	#21	[4]
International share of biological & biomedical sciences research doctorates	34%	**16%**[2025]	−18.1 pp ▼	23%	−4.3 pp ▼	#35	[4]
International share of physical sciences research doctorates	60%[2018]	**45%**[2025]	−14.4 pp ▼	38%	−1.3 pp ▼	#10	[4]
Active F-1/M-1 students, all levels	8.27K	**21.8K**[2026]	2.64× ▲	1.19M	−0.1% ▼	#18	[20]
Share of U.S. active F-1/M-1 students	0.7%	**1.8%**[2026]	+1.1 pp ▲	–	–	#18	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from India	16%	**57%**[2026]	+41.1 pp ▲	27%	+11.4 pp ▲	#2	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from China	18%	**1.9%**[2026]	−16.6 pp ▼	18%	−11.7 pp ▼	#50	[20]
Share from the two largest countries of origin	37%	**64%**[2026]	+26.5 pp ▲	45%	−0.3 pp ▼	#2	[20]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). “pp” is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

KENTUCKY – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
Countries of citizenship represented	161	**173**[2026]	+7.5% ▲	219	−2.7% ▼	#17	[20]
Active STEM F-1/M-1 students	3.43K	**4.17K**[2026]	+22% ▲	749K	+61% ▲	#30	[20]
Active STEM master's students	1.16K	**2.2K**[2026]	+90% ▲	393K	+90% ▲	#26	[20]
Active STEM doctoral students	774	**913**[2026]	+18% ▲	158K	+61% ▲	#33	[20]
Share of STEM master's students from India	69%	**68%**[2026]	−0.8 pp ▼	58%	−1.8 pp ▼	#10	[20]
U.S. students studying abroad for credit, from the state's institutions	4.59K[2017]	**3.5K**[2024]	−24% ▼	–	–	#30	[1]
Economic contribution of international students	$445M[2018]	**$296M**[2024]	−34% ▼	$42.9B	+4.6% ▲	#27	[2]
Jobs supported by international students' spending	3.19K[2018]	**1.72K**[2024]	−46% ▼	356K	−22% ▼	#31	[2]
Share of U.S. student and exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	0.4%	**0.3%**[2024]	−0.1 pp ▼	–	–	#38	[16]
Share of U.S. F-1 student admissions, by destination	0.4%	**0.3%**[2024]	−0.1 pp ▼	–	–	#37	[16]
Share of U.S. J-1 exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	0.4%	**0.3%**[2024]	−0.1 pp ▼	–	–	#42	[16]
J-1 exchange visitors starting a program in the state	1.82K	**1.15K**[2025]	−37% ▼	275K	−14% ▼	#46	[18]
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH							
Graduate students in science & engineering	4.47K	**4.54K**[2016]	+1.5% ▲	620K	+0.4% ▲	#33	[9]
S&E graduate students on temporary visas	1.21K	**1.18K**[2016]	−2.5% ▼	241K	+2.3% ▲	#35	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E graduate students	27%	**26%**[2016]	−1.1 pp ▼	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#41	[9]
Temporary-visa share of engineering graduate students	38%	**39%**[2016]	+0.6 pp ▲	57%	0.0 pp	#44	[9]
S&E postdoctoral appointees	160	**191**[2016]	+19% ▲	45.7K	+1.0% ▲	#37	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E postdocs	58%	**57%**[2016]	−1.0 pp ▼	56%	−0.9 pp ▼	#24	[9]
University R&D spending	$533M	**$788M**[2024]	+48% ▲	$118B	+71% ▲	#33	[6]
Share of U.S. university R&D	0.8%	**0.7%**[2024]	−0.1 pp ▼	–	–	#33	[6]
Federally funded share of university R&D	43%	**48%**[2024]	+5.9 pp ▲	55%	−0.2 pp ▼	#35	[6]
Business-funded share of university R&D	3.0%	**2.8%**[2024]	−0.2 pp ▼	5.4%	−0.4 pp ▼	#35	[6]
State- and locally funded share of university R&D	11%	**6.5%**[2024]	−4.5 pp ▼	5.2%	−0.4 pp ▼	#22	[6]
University R&D in mathematics and computer science	$3.94M	**$8.09M**[2024]	2.05× ▲	$5.12B	+97% ▲	#45	[6]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

KENTUCKY – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH (CONTINUED)							
University R&D in engineering	$68.2M	**$95.8M[2024]**	+40% ▲	$19.3B	+74% ▲	#36	[6]
University R&D personnel, headcount	9.28K	**9.02K[2024]**	−2.7% ▼	1.09M	+20% ▲	#33	[6]
Federal R&D obligations to the state	$297M	**$466M[2024]**	+57% ▲	$193B	+53% ▲	#40	[8]
Federal R&D obligations to universities in the state	$204M	**$322M[2024]**	+58% ▲	$44.4B	+64% ▲	#30	[8]
Defense R&D obligations to the state	$59.8M	**$38.1M[2024]**	−36% ▼	$97.2B	+60% ▲	#49	[8]
Health (HHS/NIH) R&D obligations to the state	$166M	**$231M[2024]**	+39% ▲	$48.5B	+62% ▲	#31	[8]
NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science grants performed in the state	$197M	**$287M[2025]**	+45% ▲	$45B	+47% ▲	#30	[19]
Federal R&D contracts performed in the state	$20.6M	**$19.5M[2026]**	−5.6% ▼	$59.3B	+59% ▲	#43	[19]
COLLEGE COSTS AND OUTCOMES							
Median earnings 10 years after entering college	$39K[2020]	**$42.3K[2022]**	+8.5% ▲	$47.5K	+11% ▲	#47	[15]
Median earnings 1 year after completing	–	**$43K[2025]**	–	$47.5K	–	#50	[15]
Median debt of completers	$20.9K	**$19.5K[2024]**	−6.7% ▼	$17.6K	−4.6% ▼	#18	[15]
STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$63K[2025]**	–	$68.2K	–	#39	[15]
Non-STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$42.9K[2025]**	–	$51.9K	–	#51	[15]
Bachelor's graduates: median earnings 5 years out	–	**$57.7K[2025]**	–	$68.1K	–	#50	[15]
STEM master's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$91.8K[2025]**	–	$91.6K	–	#17	[15]
Six-year bachelor's graduation rate, 4-year institutions	49%	**58%[2024]**	+9.3 pp ▲	65%	+5.3 pp ▲	#38	[4]
Completion within 150% of normal time, 2-year institutions	27%	**48%[2024]**	+20.9 pp ▲	41%	+12.1 pp ▲	#10	[4]
In-state tuition & fees, public 4-year	$12.5K	**$11.9K[2023]**	−4.6% ▼	$9.71K	−14% ▼	#14	[4]
State & local appropriations per FTE, public institutions	$7.3K	**$7.45K[2024]**	+2.1% ▲	$11.4K	+22% ▲	#45	[4]
Tuition share of core revenue, public institutions	53%	**52%[2024]**	−1.3 pp ▼	43%	−5.9 pp ▼	#15	[4]
Average full-time faculty salary (9/10-month)	$87.3K[2016]	**$76.7K[2024]**	−12% ▼	$106K	−4.6% ▼	#48	[4]
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO							
International graduates on OPT working in the state where they studied	30%	**27%[2016]**	−2.9 pp ▼	44%	−1.8 pp ▼	#37	[21]
OPT retention, bachelor's graduates	35%	**38%[2016]**	+3.1 pp ▲	58%	+0.3 pp ▲	#37	[21]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

KENTUCKY – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO (CONTINUED)							
OPT retention, master's graduates	23%	**20%**[2016]	−2.9 pp ▼	39%	−2.5 pp ▼	#40	[21]
OPT retention, STEM graduates	25%	**20%**[2016]	−4.8 pp ▼	37%	−1.9 pp ▼	#39	[21]
OPT workers employed in the state per OPT graduate of its schools	0.64	**0.66**[2016]	0.0	1.00	0.0	#34	[21]
STEM OPT extensions approved, by state of the school	153	**187**[2016]	+22% ▲	41.2K	+51% ▲	#35	[21]
Net domestic migration of bachelor's-plus adults, per 1,000 residents	−4.2	**+4.6**[2025]	+8.8 ▲	–	–	#15	[12]
Net domestic migration of graduate-degree holders	−2.88K	**−784**[2025]	– ▲	–	–	#36	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved in from another state	2.8%	**2.9%**[2025]	+0.1 pp ▲	–	–	#25	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved out to another state	3.2%	**2.4%**[2025]	−0.8 pp ▼	–	–	#37	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who arrived from abroad in the past year	3.35K	**5.29K**[2025]	+58% ▲	–	–	#28	[12]
First-time students who are in-state residents	79%[2016]	**77%**[2024]	−1.9 pp ▼	–	–	#16	[4]
Net student migration (per 100 resident first-time students)	+7[2016]	**+7**[2024]	−0.4 ▼	–	–	#24	[4]
Recent high school graduates who go to college out of state	12%[2016]	**14%**[2022]	+2.1 pp ▲	22%	+2.5 pp ▲	#43	[3]
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS							
Certified H-1B positions, by worksite	7.56K	**2.75K**[2025]	−64% ▼	914K	−24% ▼	#33	[17]
Share of U.S. certified H-1B positions	0.6%	**0.3%**[2025]	−0.3 pp ▼	–	–	#33	[17]
STEM share of certified H-1B positions	87%	**72%**[2025]	−14.8 pp ▼	76%	−7.8 pp ▼	#19	[17]
Median offered H-1B wage, nominal dollars	$65.3K	**$93.6K**[2025]	+43% ▲	$119K	+66% ▲	#38	[17]
H-1B positions at H-1B-dependent employers	56%	**35%**[2025]	−21.0 pp ▼	22%	−25.7 pp ▼	#1	[17]
Green-card labor certifications	332	**499**[2025]	+50% ▲	138K	+75% ▲	#35	[17]
Share of PERM certifications for citizens of India	62%	**40%**[2024]	−21.8 pp ▼	47%	−10.6 pp ▼	#22	[17]
PERM certifications for workers on F-1 student visas	5.2%	**4.5%**[2024]	−0.6 pp ▼	8.7%	+4.9 pp ▲	#44	[17]
PERM workers with a master's or doctorate	49%	**32%**[2024]	−16.9 pp ▼	47%	−4.9 pp ▼	#30	[17]
STEM share of PERM certifications	66%	**49%**[2025]	−16.7 pp ▼	49%	−25.8 pp ▼	#17	[17]
Median offered PERM wage, nominal dollars	$78.7K	**$100K**[2025]	+27% ▲	$100K	+9.9% ▲	#14	[17]
New lawful permanent residents (green cards), by state of residence	5.65K	**12.1K**[2024]	2.15× ▲	1.36M	+30% ▲	#22	[16]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

KENTUCKY – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS (CONTINUED)							
Share of U.S. new green-card holders	0.5%	**0.9%**[2024]	+0.4 pp ▲	–	–	#22	[16]
People naturalized as U.S. citizens, by state of residence	2.85K	**4.52K**[2024]	+59% ▲	819K	+12% ▲	#27	[16]
Share of U.S. naturalizations	0.4%	**0.6%**[2024]	+0.2 pp ▲	–	–	#27	[16]
Share of U.S. temporary-worker admissions, by destination	0.6%	**0.4%**[2024]	−0.2 pp ▼	–	–	#29	[16]
Share of U.S. H-1B worker admissions, by destination	0.3%	**0.2%**[2024]	−0.1 pp ▼	–	–	#36	[16]
Share of U.S. L-1 intracompany-transferee admissions, by destination	0.5%	**0.6%**[2024]	+0.1 pp ▲	–	–	#26	[16]
Share of U.S. O-1 extraordinary-ability worker admissions, by destination	0.1%	**0.1%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#35	[16]
New H-1B approvals (initial), by employer state	294	**393**[2026]	+34% ▲	127K	+14% ▲	#35	[13]
Continuing H-1B approvals, by employer state	651	**945**[2026]	+45% ▲	268K	+52% ▲	#29	[13]
Share of U.S. new H-1B approvals	0.3%	**0.3%**[2026]	0.0 pp	–	–	#35	[13]
Denial rate, new H-1B petitions	5.5%	**3.4%**[2026]	−2.0 pp ▼	3.4%	−3.0 pp ▼	#27	[13]
New H-1B approvals at colleges and schools (NAICS 61)	33%	**28%**[2026]	−5.6 pp ▼	8.6%	−1.7 pp ▼	#12	[13]
New H-1B approvals in professional, scientific & technical services	16%	**23%**[2026]	+6.7 pp ▲	44%	−12.5 pp ▼	#33	[13]
Five largest employers' share of new H-1B approvals	43%	**39%**[2026]	−4.2 pp ▼	9.1%	−6.7 pp ▼	#19	[13]
STEM WORKFORCE AND INNOVATION							
Workers in STEM occupations	79.2K	**113K**[2024]	+42% ▲	13.7M	+51% ▲	#30	[12]
STEM workers as a share of all workers	4.1%	**5.3%**[2024]	+1.2 pp ▲	8.1%	+2.1 pp ▲	#47	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers	7.6%	**9.2%**[2024]	+1.6 pp ▲	24%	+1.6 pp ▲	#40	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers with a graduate degree	19%	**19%**[2024]	−0.3 pp ▼	41%	+2.2 pp ▲	#41	[12]
Noncitizen share of STEM workers	5.1%	**6.4%**[2024]	+1.3 pp ▲	11%	+0.7 pp ▲	#29	[12]
STEM workers born abroad who arrived in the last 10 years	4.3%	**4.6%**[2024]	+0.3 pp ▲	7.5%	+0.3 pp ▲	#29	[12]
Share of foreign-born STEM workers born in India	35%[2019]	**37%**[2023]	+2.1 pp ▲	28%	−1.0 pp ▼	#4	[12]
Foreign-born share of residents	3.6%	**5.7%**[2025]	+2.2 pp ▲	15%	+1.3 pp ▲	#39	[12]
Foreign-born share of graduate-degree holders, 25+	7.4%	**9.5%**[2025]	+2.1 pp ▲	21%	+2.8 pp ▲	#38	[12]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

KENTUCKY – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
STEM WORKFORCE AND INNOVATION (CONTINUED)							
STEM jobs, employer survey	70K	**85.9K**[2025]	+23% ▲	10.4M	+26% ▲	#28	[10]
STEM jobs concentration vs the U.S., location quotient	0.64	**0.65**[2025]	0.0	1.00	0.0	#47	[10]
Mean annual STEM wage, nominal	$68.7K	**$94.2K**[2025]	+37% ▲	$120K	+38% ▲	#44	[10]
Median software developer wage, nominal	$83.3K[2019]	**$109K**[2025]	+31% ▲	$136K	+26% ▲	#44	[10]
Software developer jobs	7.88K	**7.66K**[2025]	−2.8% ▼	1.69M	+48% ▲	#31	[10]
Mean annual wage, all occupations, nominal	$40.9K	**$59K**[2025]	+44% ▲	$69.8K	+44% ▲	#44	[10]
Patents granted to assignees in the state	500	**229**[2025]	−54% ▼	135K	−0.6% ▼	#40	[22]
Share of U.S.-assignee patents	0.4%	**0.2%**[2025]	−0.2 pp ▼	–	–	#40	[22]
Share of the state's patents in digital technologies	12%	**15%**[2025]	+2.7 pp ▲	43%	+1.6 pp ▲	#33	[22]
Share of the state's patents in life sciences	15%	**24%**[2025]	+9.3 pp ▲	17%	+0.4 pp ▲	#15	[22]
Share of the state's patents in semiconductors	1.5%	**0.8%**[2025]	−0.7 pp ▼	2.9%	−1.7 pp ▼	#22	[22]
Women's share of inventors on the state's patents	11%	**15%**[2025]	+4.1 pp ▲	14%	+3.4 pp ▲	#7	[22]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). “pp” is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

Sources

[1] Institute of International Education. *Open Doors Report on International Educational Exchange: State Fact Sheets*. Editions 2020–2026. New York: Institute of International Education. https://opendoorsdata.org/. Accessed November 2026.

[2] NAFSA: Association of International Educators. *NAFSA International Student Economic Value Tool*. Academic years 2018–19 to 2024–25. Washington, DC: NAFSA. https://www.nafsa.org/isev. Accessed November 2026.

[3] National Center for Education Statistics. *Digest of Education Statistics*. Editions 1995–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education, Institute of Education Sciences. https://nces.ed.gov/programs/digest/. Accessed November 2026.

[4] National Center for Education Statistics. *Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS)*. Survey files, 1980–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education, Institute of Education Sciences. https://nces.ed.gov/ipeds/. Accessed November 2026.

[5] National Center for Education Statistics. *National Assessment of Educational Progress (NAEP)*. NAEP Data Service, 1990–2024. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education, Institute of Education Sciences. https://www.nationsreportcard.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[6] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Higher Education Research and Development Survey*. Data tables, FY2003–2024. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/higher-education-research-development. Accessed November 2026.

[7] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Survey of Earned Doctorates*. Data tables, 1994–2025. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/earned-doctorates. Accessed November 2026.

[8] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Survey of Federal Funds for Research and Development*. Data tables, FY1985–2024. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/federal-funds-research-development. Accessed November 2026.

[9] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates in Science and Engineering*. Data tables, 1994–2024. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/graduate-students-postdoctorates-s-e. Accessed November 2026.

[10] U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. *Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics*. State estimates, 1999–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Labor. https://www.bls.gov/oes/. Accessed November 2026.

[11] U.S. Census Bureau, Center for Economic Studies. *Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes (PSEO)*. Release R2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Commerce. https://lehd.ces.census.gov/data/pseo_experimental.html. Accessed November 2026.

[12] U.S. Census Bureau. *American Community Survey*. 1-year estimates and Public Use Microdata Sample, 2010–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Commerce. https://data.census.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[13] U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services. *H-1B Employer Data Hub*. Fiscal years 2009–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://www.uscis.gov/tools/reports-and-studies/h-1b-employer-data-hub. Accessed November 2026.

[14] U.S. Department of Education, Office for Civil Rights. *Civil Rights Data Collection*. School years 1980–81 to 2023–24. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education. https://civilrightsdata.ed.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[15] U.S. Department of Education. *College Scorecard*. Institution and field-of-study data, 1996–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education. https://collegescorecard.ed.gov/data/. Accessed November 2026.

[16] U.S. Department of Homeland Security, Office of Homeland Security Statistics. *Yearbook of Immigration Statistics*. Fiscal years 1996–2024. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://ohss.dhs.gov/topics/immigration/yearbook. Accessed November 2026.

[17] U.S. Department of Labor, Employment and Training Administration, Office of Foreign Labor Certification. *LCA and PERM Disclosure Data*. Fiscal years 2008–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Labor. https://www.dol.gov/agencies/eta/foreign-labor/performance. Accessed November 2026.

[18] U.S. Department of State, Bureau of Educational and Cultural Affairs. *BridgeUSA: Exchange Visitor Program Participants by State*. 2015–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of State. https://j1visa.state.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[19] U.S. Department of the Treasury, Bureau of the Fiscal Service. *USAspending.gov*. Award data, FY2008–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of the Treasury. https://www.usaspending.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[20] U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement, Student and Exchange Visitor Program. *SEVIS by the Numbers: Data Mapping Tool*. Monthly data, 2014–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/sevis-data-mapping-tool. Accessed November 2026.

[21] U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement. *Student and Exchange Visitor Information System (SEVIS) Data*. Freedom of Information Act releases, 2008–2016. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://www.ice.gov/foia/library. Accessed November 2026.

[22] U.S. Patent and Trademark Office. *PatentsView*. Annualized patent data, grant years 1976–2025. Alexandria, VA: U.S. Patent and Trademark Office. https://patentsview.org/. Accessed November 2026.